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A Speculative History of Culture Mechanics

Status, purpose, and reading rule

This essay preserves the originating historical and causal story behind Culture Mechanics. It is written for human readers who want to see how the parts of the theory might fit into one long development—from ancestral shared intentionality, through priests and printing presses, to radio, platforms, and artificial intelligence.

It is **not** a semantic definition, an authoritative source for the constructs, or an established history of ideas. It is a canonical record of the project's speculative background narrative. The authoritative documents define the theory; this essay points into them but they do not depend upon this essay. It is therefore also excluded from the Markdown source bundles intended for ChatGPT inference.

The following labels keep unlike claims visible:

Label	Meaning in this essay
Established background	A comparatively well-supported empirical, technical, or historical claim.
Source interpretation	What a named author or work is understood here to contribute; rival readings may exist.
Project synthesis	A connection made by Culture Mechanics between materials that their original authors did not combine.
Originating hypothesis	A definite claim proposed by the originating author and retained in recognizable form because it organizes the inquiry.
Strong speculation	A high-risk causal or historical proposal whose present evidence is inadequate.
Open test	Evidence that could strengthen, narrow, or defeat a proposal.

Epistemic labels are not instructions to make the originating claim disappear. They make it possible to state that claim clearly and then ask what would have to be true for it to survive.

The story in one paragraph

Originating hypothesis: Human beings possess an evolved capacity for a real *we-mode*: shared attention, shared intention, obligation to a joint undertaking, and, under some conditions, strongly synchronized collective agency. In small ancestral bands this capacity was bounded by distance, group size, memory, scarce contact, and the labor required to teach, ritualize, interpret, and enforce a mythology. Priests, missionaries, teachers, and organizers were the original reproduction infrastructure of large multi-mind-selves. Writing, printing, newspapers, radio, television, digital platforms, and now generative AI progressively reduced that reproduction cost, extended coupling radius, increased message fidelity and repetition, and shortened feedback time. Idealist and collectivist thinkers, uneasy about modern individualism and the dissolution of inherited bonds, may have stumbled upon, reconstructed, or deliberately refined mythologies capable of occupying this enlarged infrastructure. The proposed result was an upward spiral in Culture Mechanics: increasingly cheap endogenous formation, attempted purposive construction, transmission, activation, observation, and correction of collective programs, punctuated by *Resonanzkatastrophen* in which a public became intensely synchronized and destructive. The French Revolution is the first candidate within the specific modern regime proposed here; nationalism, totalitarian broadcasting, thought reform, digital platforms, and AI-assisted alignment are later stages. This is the story the essay will test, not a conclusion the existing evidence has already earned. Franz Josef Radermacher supplies an independent precursor through his layered systems architecture, humanity-as-superorganism proposal, institutional nervous-system and queen/bottleneck comparisons, and later warning about obedient AI serving a regulated ant state that extinguishes individual freedom. The project joins those source lines into its AI queen-bee possibility; it does not attribute that complete conjunction to him. A separate older-mind branch asks whether some cultures cultivated bicameral-like god-enactment regimes in which divine or ancestral agent-models received more immediate authority than a continuous autobiographical *I*, and whether rituals could temporarily enact those gods as multi-mind-selves. This Jaynes–Bach bridge is strong speculation, not a premise required by the modern media history. The same media can also make incompatible local orders mutually visible: under plural conditions, print may denaturalize first-order rules and create pressure for lifted rules of coexistence rather than synchronize everyone around one answer. A distinct Christian-architecture branch proposes that Christianity held differentiated persons in one shared order above the cultural- interoperability floor (anti-Babel floor) without demanding total fusion: it joined them through Christ, placed the highest kingdom beyond terrestrial political possession, protected personal and household ownership, and thereby opened cultural space in which individuality could develop. Durkheim supplies independent support for part of this genealogy: he interprets Christianity as a "restrained individualism" that moved piety toward inward conviction and intention, made the person responsible before God, differentiated spiritual from temporal authority, and thereby prepared science, free inquiry, and the later religion of the human person. His account supports the cultural and jurisdictional branch, not the separate kinship or genetic mechanism. A separate, still more speculative recipient-side hypothesis proposes that Western Christian restrictions on close-kin marriage widened reproductive, social, and mythological fields; regional commercial and institutional ecologies then rewarded dispositions compatible with individual autonomy and impersonal cooperation; and repeated selection may even have produced polygenic distributional change over historical time. Haidt's fast-evolution argument supplies the general gene–culture opening for that timescale, not the Europe-specific pathway or result. Its strongest extension asks whether some forms of **real individuality** began as partial malfunctions of the homo-duplex machinery: attenuation, narrowed reach, or an opening of the normally opaque cultural co-processor to inspection by the main CPU. Individualist institutions may have made some such variations survivable, useful, and eventually selectable without making malfunction by itself equivalent to autonomy or moral adulthood. The resulting social arc may run from clan-scale interpersonal immediacy, through kinship widening and institutionally mediated cooperation among unlike persons, to Durkheim's world of increasingly differentiated consciousness. Durkheimian Humanism is interpreted here as a constructive bridge across that difference: every concrete person receives sacred standing even when no rich empirical personality is common to all. If differentiation eventually outruns translation, shared procedure, and the reproduction of that standing, the projected failure is **very-small-group Babelization**: interoperability survives mainly inside tiny islands. **Individual Babelization** is retained as its ultra-extreme limiting case—not individuality itself but a cultural-interoperability island approaching one person. Northern Italy, the Rhine corridor, the Low Countries, and Britain explain the proposed regional concentration and amplification of that development, not the human capacity for individuality by themselves. This auxiliary branch is retained because it generates tests and may explain differential resonance and the ferocity of later struggles for *Deutungshoheit*; the media history does not depend upon it.

One-way map into the theory

This narrative borrows its parts from the authoritative theory without becoming their semantic home:

Part of the story	Authoritative theoretical home
Homo duplex, local bigOther, single-slot exclusivity, programming, *Beseelung*, agentified enactment, propagation, jealousy, the multi-mind-self, fusion, and the Jaynes–Bach comparison	*Culture Mechanics*
Mechanical solidarity, field formation, observability, cultural forgetting, contemporary witnesses, crowd modes, episodic multi-mind-selves, and epistemic capture	*Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*
Lifted rules, piety toward the real, corrigibility, and institutional succession	*Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity*
Reality correction and the recognizable repertoire of deceptive or corrosive language	*Linguistic Tricks: A Semantic Inventory*
Resonance, mythology construction and replacement, media coupling, the coupling thermostat, genetic-hardware hypotheses, cultural interoperability and its breakdown (Babelization), and Critical Theory	*Mythology Construction*
"The Quantum Mechanics of Psychology," lasers, magnetism, gravity, sleeping–waking collective states, crowd modes, cross-theory Jaynes–Bach mapping panels, and the model-usefulness yardstick	*Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics: A Semantic Inventory*
Culture Program ecology, systemic skeleton and living cultural body, institutional nervous systems, superorganismic coordination, Praxis, common-mode AI exposure, and the alignment-sovereign hazard	*Culture Program Ecology*

If this essay conflicts with one of those documents about the meaning of a construct, the authoritative document controls. Historical evidence can, of course, correct both the story and the theory.

1. The biological opening: the human capacity for a *we*

The starting point is not mass media. It is a species capacity that media can recruit.

Michael Tomasello's shared-intentionality programme distinguishes merely coordinated conduct from collaboration organized around shared goals, joint intentions, reciprocal roles, communication about the undertaking, and some sense of joint commitment. A review of this research describes the proposed difference between human cooperation and chimpanzee cooperation in exactly these terms: human partners can be concerned not only with their own goal but also with the partner's orientation toward the shared goal. See Alicia P. Melis and Michael Tomasello, "How is human cooperation different?".

Established-background caution: This does not show that chimpanzees have "absolutely no synchronization mechanism whatsoever." Chimpanzees coordinate, communicate, hunt, select partners, and solve some collaborative problems. The stronger Tomasello thesis is that they lack, or show much less evidence of, the human form of shared intentionality and normative joint commitment. That thesis is itself contested by comparative evidence; see the review "Empirical challenges from the comparative and developmental literature to the Shared Intentionality Theory". The image of two chimpanzees not carrying a log together remains memorable because it directs attention to the difference between parallel action and a represented *we*. It should not be expanded into the claim that apes never coordinate.

Jonathan Haidt compresses the human contrast into the memorable heading of chapter 9 of *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People Are Divided by Politics and Religion*: "We Are 90 Percent Chimp and 10 Percent Bee." The percentages are a metaphor, not an anatomical or genetic measurement. The "chimp" represents ordinary individual competition and social maneuvering; the "bee" represents the capacity to cross, at least temporarily, into groupish self-transcendence.

Project synthesis: Haidt's hive switch, Tomasello's shared intentionality, and the Culture Mechanics co-processor slot describe neighboring but non-identical things. Shared intentionality makes a human *we* possible. The hive-switch image captures the felt transition into groupishness. Culture Mechanics proposes an architecture through which mythology, the local bigOther, reciprocal signaling, and the distributed field can turn that capacity into a durable or episodic multi-mind-self.

```
human capacity for shared intentionality
+ local cultural programming
+ reciprocal recognition and obligation
+ a shared symbolic protocol
-> possibility of a collectively enacted agent
```

This does not mean every collaboration is a multi-mind-self. Two people carrying a log can share an intention without possessing the continuing collective memory, judgment, ownership, and agency required by the theory's stronger threshold.

2. A supernormal stimulus for the hive switch

A **supernormal stimulus** is an artificial or unusually intense stimulus that elicits a stronger response than the normally encountered natural stimulus. The APA Dictionary of Psychology gives the classic example of a bird preferring an exaggerated artificial egg to its own egg.

The originating formulation is vivid:

> **The synchronization mechanism provided by the co-processor slot is a kind of superstimulus.**

Used strictly, the mechanism is not itself a stimulus. The more precise proposal is:

> **Modern mythologies, media environments, and reciprocal social signals can provide supernormal stimulation to an evolved human capacity for shared intentionality, affiliation, imitation, sacredness, and synchronization.**

The original sugar comparison still carries part of the intuition. Evolution can build a powerful appetite in an environment where external scarcity usually prevents sustained excess. Refined sugar then supplies an intensity and concentration that the old environment rarely supplied. The important claim is not that humans literally evolved no brakes, but that ancestral environments may have supplied brakes externally—scarcity, distance, slow propagation, small group size, face-to-face accountability, competing obligations, and the physical cost of repeated assembly.

Strong speculation: The hive-switch capacity may be similarly vulnerable. In a small band, synchronization is naturally limited in radius and duration. Modern communications can expose millions or billions of people to repeated identity cues, moral emotions, common enemies, sacred symbols, and visible conformity at a speed and concentration for which the capacity was not selected.

The proposed causal pattern is:

```
ancestral we-capacity
+ supernormal mythological cues
+ enlarged communication radius
+ rapid reciprocal confirmation
+ reduced exposure to counter-signals
-> possible synchronization overdrive
```

The proposal concerns susceptibility, not destiny. The same communications infrastructure can widen inquiry, reveal dissent, connect counter-publics, and produce cultural interoperability breakdown (Babelization) instead of one coherent public. A larger coupling radius can create a global laser crowd, many rival domains, a turbulent mixture, or no stable order at all.

3. Priests and missionaries as the original network

Large collective beings existed before electronic media. They were expensive.

Project synthesis: A priest, missionary, teacher, court poet, ritual specialist, or political organizer can be modeled as part of a mythology's reproduction and error-correction infrastructure. Such people perform at least four separable functions:

1. **Preservation and interpretation:** retain narratives, classifications, rituals, and answers when ordinary memory would drift.
2. **Recruitment and formation:** teach newcomers how to perceive, feel, speak, and act within the operative lens.
3. **Activation and synchronization:** assemble people, mark sacred time, conduct rites, and turn stored programming into a shared episode.

4. **Correction and enforcement:** identify deviance, settle authorized meaning, reward fidelity, punish defection, and repair the local network.

Originally, these functions required people to travel, preach, copy manuscripts, teach children, stage festivals, hear confessions, monitor conduct, and repeat the same material generation after generation. The human carrier was not just a message pipe. The carrier embodied authority, interpreted ambiguity, provided an emotional model, and observed the recipient's response.

This is why the phrase **"printing made missionaries cheaper"** is useful but incomplete. A printed page can reproduce words at very low marginal cost. It does not by itself supply trust, initiation, ritual presence, local adaptation, surveillance, or the common knowledge that others have also accepted the message. Each later medium automates some priestly or missionary functions while leaving others to people and institutions.

4. The falling cost of collective reproduction

The proposed historical ratchet is best stated as a change in costs and controls:

Transmission regime	What becomes cheaper or stronger	What remains difficult or newly dangerous
Oral teaching and ritual	Embodied trust, local emotional intensity, correction in person	Slow copying, small radius, carrier loss, local variation
Writing and manuscript	Memory across time and distance, textual authority	Copying and literacy remain expensive; feedback is slow
Printing, pamphlets, and newspapers	High-fidelity replication, recurrent exposure, wider publics, rapid polemics	Publishers and distributors gate access; readers' responses are still hard to observe
Radio and film	Simultaneous mass attention, voice, rhythm, spectacle, centralized message control	One-to-many broadcasting offers weak recipient feedback but powerful agenda control
Television	Repeated audiovisual presence inside the home, national event synchronization	High production and channel costs concentrate selection power
Digital social platforms	Every recipient can become a repeater; metrics make assent, outrage, and exclusion visible; feedback approaches real time	Algorithmic opacity, cascades, rivalry, fragmentation, surveillance, and common-mode error
Generative AI	Personalized explanation, translation, variation, rebuttal, role simulation, and continuous production	Scalable persuasion, artificial consensus, authority laundering, and automated steering

No technology determines the mythology it carries. Printing reproduced scientific criticism as well as sectarian polemic; radio carried music and emergency information as well as propaganda; platforms can coordinate rescue or persecution. The historical hypothesis concerns a reduction in the cost of constructing and maintaining collective programming, not an intrinsically ideological essence of the medium.

The crucial variables include:

- marginal cost per exposure;
- geographical and social radius;
- fidelity and authorized interpretation;
- repetition and emotional vividness;
- simultaneity;
- visibility of other recipients' responses;
- speed of positive and negative feedback;
- capacity to select, suppress, or flood counter-signals;
- and the cost of monitoring, correcting, and replacing participants.

The strongest media do not merely send messages farther. They close the loop between message, response, observed response, algorithmic or institutional selection, and the next message.

5. Christianity: differentiated unity without fusion

The media story explains how collective programming became cheaper. It does not yet explain why a civilization might develop strong common bonds while also opening protected space for differentiated persons. The originating hypothesis assigns Christianity a special role in that preparation:

> **Christianity produces differentiated unity, not fusion into a transparent terrestrial collective consciousness. It can hold persons in one shared order above the cultural-interoperability floor (anti-Babel floor) while preserving the space in which individuality can develop.**

This is not the claim that Christianity is weakly unifying. Every living culture must create some shared intelligibility, obligation, and solidarity. If the operative shared meta-order becomes too thin or loses too much span, cultural interoperability can fall below the anti-Babel floor. Nor does the claim deny that a church could meet Culture Mechanics' threshold for a multi-mind-self. It distinguishes **differentiated unity** from **subjecthood absorption (fusion)**. The strongest Christian images join persons through a shared relation to Christ while preserving different persons, languages, gifts, functions, and bounded worldly jurisdictions.

The proposal has two separable causal branches. The first is **mythological and constitutional**: Christian teaching supplies a grammar of personhood, differentiated unity, transcendent authority, and protected ownership. The second is **demographic and institutional**: the Western Church's marriage-and-family programme weakens intensive kinship and widens the field beyond the clan. The first branch is developed here; the second connects forward to "The genetic-hardware auxiliary hypothesis".

Émile Durkheim's 1898 essay "L'individualisme et les intellectuels", translated by Mark Traugott as "Individualism and the Intellectuals" in *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society*, pp. 43–57, supplies an external genealogy for the first branch. Durkheim was intervening in the Dreyfus-era struggle over individual rights, authority, and national cohesion. He is therefore neither a neutral historian nor a calibrated causal instrument. His situatedness nevertheless gives him access to a still-active conflict over whether individualism continued or destroyed the Christian inheritance. His answer is explicit: modern moral individualism develops tendencies already introduced by Christianity.

5.1 Jesus addresses a person who must answer

Source interpretation: The Christian call is addressed to persons who must answer for themselves. In Matthew 16:24–27, Jesus says that whoever wishes to follow him must take up the cross, and he ends with judgment of each according to that person's conduct. The disciple joins a community, receives teaching, and enters obligations, but does not become morally interchangeable with the crowd. The call can be preached collectively; the answer is nevertheless personally owned.

Durkheim describes the same movement in historical language. He contrasts the religion of the ancient city, organized predominantly through external practice, with Christian piety grounded in inward faith and personal conviction. By making intention central to the moral value of an act, Christianity moves an important part of moral jurisdiction into a place that external observers cannot inspect directly. The person becomes responsible for conduct before the self and God, not merely before the visible conformity tribunal of the city. See Durkheim, pp. 52–53.

In Culture Mechanics terms, this matters because the person is not merely an organ whose right answer is exhausted by conformity to the presently enacted group. Conscience remains answerable to a reference that can judge both person and collective. The Christian community may form a real *we*, but it does not become the final source of the good merely because it is synchronized.

This is not yet low-gain homo duplex, an empty collar, or CPU-only morality. The inner tribunal can be emotionally powerful. The proposed individualizing change lies instead in **reference and jurisdiction**: the immediate human field loses its monopoly because the local Christian bigOther represents an authority that can condemn the crowd, ruler, clan, and even church office. A strong sacred presence can therefore open personal standing against terrestrial collective presence without becoming weak.

This is a structural reading, not a claim that Christian traditions invented the individual from nothing, that every biblical passage has a modern individualist meaning, or that historical Christians consistently respected conscience.

5.2 Cultural interoperability without homogenization

Four New Testament pictures carry the proposed architecture:

Christian picture	Culture-mechanical reading
The Body of Christ	The body consists of different members with different gifts and functions. Unity preserves differentiation. 1 Corinthians 12 insists both that there is one body and that the body is not one part but many; the Spirit distributes gifts to persons individually.
Pentecost	Pentecost supplies an anti-Babel image of movement above the cultural-interoperability floor through mutual intelligibility while retaining different languages: the fire rests upon each person, different tongues are spoken, and hearers understand in their own languages. See Acts 2:1–13.
The Holy Spirit	The Holy Spirit acts within and assists persons; he is not an emergent collective consciousness generated by synchronized believers. In John 14:16–26, the Advocate remains with and in the disciples, teaches, and reminds. The source of unity is given to them; it is not manufactured by their mutual imitation.
Shared relation to Christ	Unity occurs through a shared relationship to Christ, not through the disappearance of personal boundaries into a terrestrial collective self. Christ is the common center; the group is not its own god.

The compressed pattern is:

```
one transcendent reference
+ many persons
+ different gifts, functions, and languages
+ mutual intelligibility and service
-> cultural interoperability above the anti-Babel floor
   + differentiated unity without collective fusion
```

The distinction is not between a culture and no culture. A merely private faith with no shared worship, language, memory, teaching, or obligation could not sustain a church. The distinction is between a common symbolic-affective field that joins differentiated persons and the far-end ideal in which the persons are imagined as transparent drops dissolved into one earthly consciousness.

In the authoritative vocabulary, the pictures occupy different axes. Cultural interoperability asks whether differentiated groups remain mutually intelligible participants in one shared field. Subjecthood absorption asks whether persons retain legitimate judgment, conscience, purpose, property, relationships, refusal, and exit against the collective. The Christian reading proposed here is therefore **high interoperability with low subjecthood absorption**, not merely "less synchronization." Its body image also has a clockwork affinity: different members and gifts contribute through differentiated functions. Worship can contain bounded laser synchronization in song, prayer, ritual, and common attention without generalizing that alignment into comprehensive terrestrial jurisdiction.

The anti-Babel label therefore names a **floor**, not a positive form of unity. The positive form proposed here is differentiated unity. Its interoperability is hypothesized to depend on the effective thickness and span of shared lifted solidarity: the shared Christian grammar must be deep enough to generate binding translation and jurisdictional answers, and broad enough to connect the relevant persons and institutions. The first-order relation $I \approx kT_LS_L$ and its nonlinear boundaries are defined in *Mythology Construction*, "Cultural interoperability and its breakdown (Babelization)".

5.3 A kingdom not of this world and bounded terrestrial jurisdiction

In John 18:36, Jesus tells Pilate that his kingdom does not belong to this world and points to his followers' refusal to fight as evidence of the difference. This sentence does not by itself contain the later modern doctrine of church–state separation. It nevertheless makes a decisive split imaginable: the ultimate sacred order is not identical with the state, the ruler, the nation, the party, or any other terrestrial multi-mind-self.

Originating interpretation: Locating the highest kingdom beyond political possession places a limit upon every worldly collective's claim to the whole person. Church and state can remain institutions with real authority, and either can overreach, but neither becomes divine merely by conquering the other. The person can stand within several bounded worldly relations while remaining ultimately answerable beyond them.

That architecture can support a path toward differentiated jurisdiction:

```
personal call and conscience
+ a transcendent source that can judge the collective
+ an ultimate kingdom not identical with political rule
-> conceptual room for bounded terrestrial authority
-> possible church-state differentiation and personal jurisdiction
```

The arrows name a historical possibility, not a deduction from one verse. Actual Christian polities repeatedly fused ecclesiastical and political power, coerced belief, and claimed comprehensive first-order authority. The historical question is whether the internal distinction also gave critics a language with which to oppose those arrangements.

Durkheim makes this proposed consequence unusually explicit. He attributes to Christianity a "definitive separation" of spiritual and temporal authority and argues that, by leaving worldly questions to human dispute, Christ opened the temporal field to "science and free inquiry." See "Individualism and the Intellectuals," pp. 52–53. The causal claim about the rapid progress of science is sweeping and should not be accepted merely on Durkheim's authority. The narrower mechanism is more portable: if final sacred truth and terrestrial government are not identical, then some worldly questions can become disputable without the whole sacred order collapsing. That jurisdictional opening can protect inquiry even while faith remains binding.

5.4 The Decalogue protects *mine* and *yours*

The Christian inheritance of the Decalogue adds a material boundary. Exodus 20:15–17 forbids stealing and coveting a neighbor's house or anything belonging to the neighbor. Whatever later theory of property one adopts, those commands presuppose a morally intelligible distinction between *mine* and *yours*. The neighbor is not merely an organ temporarily administering resources that already belong without remainder to one collective subject.

The originating conclusion is sharp:

> **In the originating modern shorthand, the Ten Commandments strongly protect private property.**

The more historically portable formulation is:

> **The Decalogue installs private ownership as a morally protected personal or household jurisdiction. Christianity regulates the owner but does not abolish the owner.**

Christian teaching can impose duties of stewardship, almsgiving, hospitality, mercy, restitution, and care for the poor. Those duties limit what ownership morally permits; they do not require that the giver and recipient be the same collective owner. Charity has conceptual force precisely because a person gives what the person might otherwise retain. Even the radical sharing described in Acts does not make abolition automatic: in Acts 5:1–4, Peter says that Ananias's land remained his before sale and that the proceeds remained under his control. The wrong named in the passage is deception, not failure to surrender compulsory communal title.

This is not a claim that the Decalogue supplies a complete Lockean, capitalist, or modern constitutional theory of property. Biblical law arose in a different social world, and Christian traditions disagree about the content and limits of ownership. The narrower culture-mechanical point is that no stealing, no coveting, voluntary gift, and stewardship all preserve an owner with a boundary.

The contrast with the subjecthood-absorption (fusion) interpretation can be stated materially:

Christian ownership architecture	Marxist absorptive or fusion architecture as read here
Mine and *yours* are legitimate moral jurisdictions.	Private productive ownership represents alienated separation.
Taking another person's property is prohibited.	Transfer of productive property to the collective is treated as emancipation.
Coveting another's property is morally disordered.	Dissatisfaction with unequal private ownership can be morally directed into collective transfer.
Charity means giving what one could legitimately retain.	Distribution becomes allocation internal to the collective owner.

Christian ownership architecture	Marxist absorptive or fusion architecture as read here
The owner remains accountable to God for stewardship and use.	The individual owner is displaced by society, the proletariat, or "the people."

This is the chapter's subjecthood-absorption reconstruction, not a claim that every criticism of inequality is covetous or that every form of public ownership erases persons. The later ownership analysis distinguishes genuine bounded collective owners from the mythical owner whose powers are exercised by administrators.

5.5 Durkheim's genealogy: Christianity as restrained individualism

Durkheim's dangerous claim can be restated in the project's vocabulary:

> **Christianity is not individualism's defeated antagonist. Modern Humanism is, in part, Christianity's more fully developed descendant.**

His own wording is that Christianity's originality included "a remarkable development of the individualistic spirit." He calls Christianity a "restrained individualism" suited to an earlier historical condition and says that the modern individualistic ethic "derived from" Christian morality. See Durkheim, pp. 52–53. This was an argumentative reversal. Durkheim's opponents proposed Christian morality as the cure for individualism; he replied that the proposed cure was an earlier form of the development they wished to reverse.

"Individualism" can mislead here. Durkheim does not mean the empirical *me* maximizing private advantage. He distinguishes utilitarian egoism from a moral religion whose sacred object is the human person wherever embodied. In the project's preferred vocabulary, that second position is better called **Humanism**: every concrete person receives protected standing because each participates in Humanity, not because that person's desires always prevail. Durkheim's modern religion of the human person can therefore command sacrifice, discipline, justice, and solidarity while prohibiting sacrifice *of* one person merely to a collective aggregate. His argument appears on pp. 45–49.

The genealogy reconstructed from the essay is:

```
ancient civic religion:
external practice + visible conformity + city-centred sacred order
                            ↓
Christian inward turn:
faith + personal conviction + morally decisive intention
                            ↓
the person becomes answerable before God
and gains an inward jurisdiction not exhausted by public judgment
                            ↓
spiritual and temporal authority become distinguishable
                            ↓
worldly questions become available to dispute,
science, and free inquiry
                            ↓
Christian "restrained individualism"
                            ↓ expanding society + division of labour
persons and their consciousnesses differentiate more extensively
                            ↓
modern Humanism:
the concrete human person becomes the remaining common sacred object
```

This sequence adds something important to the claim that Jesus "talks to us individually." The individual answer is not merely a private religious episode. It changes the architecture of authority. If inward intention matters, the public ritual tribunal cannot read the whole moral fact from outward conformity. If conscience is answerable to God, the presently synchronized crowd cannot become true merely by being the crowd. If the final kingdom is not identical with terrestrial government, political power cannot straightforwardly become the highest sacred judge. Each move removes one part of the person from exhaustive possession by the immediate human collective.

Pauline Christianity supplies a concrete lifted form of that change. Romans 14 permits different conclusions about food and days while making faithfulness, conscience, peace, and the effect upon the neighbour governing

considerations. The shared Christian order therefore need not store one identical concrete answer for every person and circumstance:

```
shared Christian generator
(faithfulness + conscience + love + peace)
+ person and situation
→ potentially different first-order conduct
```

The binding order remains complete, but its force moves upward from uniform answers to rules for generating conduct. This is the Pauline-Christianity boundary case in the authoritative order-level catalogue. It illustrates how strong Christian formation can authorize difference without reducing obligation to preference.

Durkheim then connects this inward and jurisdictional preparation to a second historical process: expanding societies and a deepening division of labour orient people toward different parts of reality, so the contents of consciousness increasingly differ from person to person. Definite inherited practices can no longer supply the whole common order. In his reconstruction, Humanity becomes the last sufficiently general object around which these differentiated persons can still form a moral community. See Durkheim, pp. 51–54.

Culture Mechanics can translate—but must not attribute—this development as:

```
Christianity changes what the collar ultimately represents
and where first-order human authority stops
                          ↓
persons acquire protected inward and worldly jurisdictions
                          ↓
division of labour and institutional plurality make
their concrete lives and judgments increasingly different
                          ↓
a lifted Humanist meta-order sacralizes every concrete person
while permitting divergent first-order lives
```

This is not Durkheim's PCI-slot language, and he does not distinguish local bigOther, distributed field, multi-mind-self, order level, or subjecthood absorption. The translation is a Culture Mechanics interpretation of the pattern he describes.

The evidential boundary can be stated precisely:

Durkheim supplies	Culture Mechanics takes as a candidate mechanism	Durkheim does not establish
A genealogy from external civic practice to inward Christian faith, conviction, and intention	The immediate human conformity field loses exhaustive moral jurisdiction	That Christianity uniquely invented inwardness or individual responsibility
Personal accountability before God	A transcendent reference can protect judgment against crowd, clan, ruler, and office	That Christian consciences were historically free from ecclesiastical coercion
Spiritual–temporal differentiation and an asserted opening to science and free inquiry	Divided authority can create jurisdictional space for correction and investigation	That Christianity alone caused modern science, constitutionalism, or liberalism
Christianity as "restrained individualism" and modern individualism as its continuation	A powerful inherited programme can contain or generate a more lifted person-protecting successor	That every Christian branch develops in that direction
Social expansion, division of labour, and increasing personal differentiation	Humanism can function as a constructive common meta-order when concrete sameness recedes	The close-kin-marriage mechanism, genetic drift, collar malfunction, or the projected endpoint of Babelization

Durkheim therefore strengthens the cultural genealogy without closing the historical case. Judaism, Greek and Roman thought, Germanic institutions, medieval corporate liberties, cities, commerce, legal development, the Reformation, and other processes remain possible co-causes or rivals. His essay also does not decide whether Humanism accurately discovers a common human essence or constructively persuades very different persons to

grant one another common sacred standing. The contrast is developed in "Rousseau's analytic common core and Durkheim's constructed Humanity".

5.6 Christianity as space-opener

The mythological branch can now be combined with the demographic branch without confusing them:

```
individual call
+ personal conscience
+ differentiated unity
+ transcendent limit on worldly collectives
+ protected personal and household ownership
+ weakening of intensive kinship through Western Church marriage rules
-> wider personal, household, associational, and institutional jurisdictions
-> cultural space in which individuality can become visible and legitimate
```

Originating hypothesis: Christianity did not simply cause modern individualism as a doctrine. It first opened the *space of possibility*. Its proper architecture made it possible to belong strongly without treating the earthly collective as the whole person; its marriage-and-family intervention widened the social field in which non-kin persons had to cooperate. Regional commercial, legal, and institutional ecologies could then reward and amplify individuality. The later stories of northern Italy, the Rhine corridor, Enlightenment institutions, and the high-risk polygenic-drift branch propose why that possibility became especially visible in some regions rather than everywhere Christianity was present.

On this account, Christianity did not merely leave an accidental gap in which individuality later appeared. Its moral architecture positively protected several of the boundaries—person, conscience, allegiance beyond the state, household, and property—from which individual sovereignty could grow.

This formulation prevents two causal overclaims. Christian theology alone does not explain regional timing, and exogamy alone does not explain the normative defense of the person. The proposed outcome arises from their interaction with commerce, cities, jurisdictional plurality, institutions, migration, cultural learning, and, only in the auxiliary strong version, selection.

Durkheim directly supports the inwardness, intention, conscience, spiritual–temporal differentiation, free-inquiry, and Christian-to-Humanist parts of this construction. He does not establish the Decalogue interpretation, the Western Church marriage mechanism, the regional-selection account, genetic drift, or the collar-malfunction hypothesis. Those remain separately burdened project claims.

5.7 Subjecthood absorption, fusion ideology, and the far end

The earlier image of "drops of water in a clear pond" was initially made too strong: it is not the definition of every multi-mind-self. A multi-mind-self can possess collective memory, judgment, agency, and ownership while retaining differentiated members and bounded subordinate jurisdictions. **Total fusion** is a far-end aspiration, not the threshold for collective agency.

The authoritative definition is in *Culture Mechanics*, "Differentiated unity and subjecthood absorption (fusion)":

> **A fusion ideology treats the separate person as an incomplete, alienated, or falsely conscious fragment and seeks to reconstitute persons as organs of one collectively enacted subject with increasingly comprehensive jurisdiction.**

It helps distinguish three positions:

Position	Relation between person and collective
Differentiated unity / person-preserving collective agency	The collective can act, remember, judge, and own; members retain different functions, judgments, relationships, and protected subordinate jurisdictions.
Subjecthood-absorptive collective agency	Personal judgment, conscience, purpose, property, loyalty, identity, relationships, refusal, and exit are increasingly subordinated to the collective programme.

Position	Relation between person and collective
Total fusion	High subjecthood absorption combines with comprehensive jurisdiction and closed correction or exit; the person is imagined as a transparent organ with no finally private jurisdiction, a drop in the one clear pond.

These are positions on a spectrum, not three biological species or a second authoritative taxonomy of multi-mind-selves. A movement can demand fusion yet fail to form a competent collective agent. Conversely, a highly capable collective agent can remain differentiated and constitutionally bounded. The question is not only how much collective agency exists, but what happens to the person and to jurisdiction as that agency strengthens.

Cultural interoperability and subjecthood absorption must therefore be crossed, not collapsed:

	Low subjecthood absorption	High subjecthood absorption
Above the cultural-interoperability floor	Differentiated unity across groups; this is the Christian architecture proposed here	One highly interoperable but increasingly absorptive collective order
Below the cultural-interoperability floor	Weak common agency among relatively independent groups	Several internally synchronized and absorptive local laser domains unable to sustain one legitimate common order

The first column is not automatically wise or good, and the second row is not automatically peaceful. The matrix merely prevents two different questions from being answered with one word. The same distinction clarifies the dynamic analogy: clockwork coordination has an affinity with differentiated unity; bounded laser synchronization can serve it; generalized and jurisdictionalized laser synchronization creates fusion pressure when alignment becomes compulsory across domains and correction, refusal, or exit lose standing.

5.8 Christianity and Marxism as opposing ideal types

The originating theory uses Marxism as the sharp contrast because its strongest subjecthood-absorption reading makes the earthly collective rather than a transcendent Christ the subject into which persons are to be reconciled:

> **Christianity says: become one in Christ while remaining different members. The Marxist fusion ideal says: overcome alienated individuality by becoming organs of one historically realized true consciousness.**

The contrast can be made inspectable:

Dimension	Christian differentiated-unity architecture above the anti-Babel floor	Marxist subjecthood-absorption (fusion) pole as reconstructed here
Primary addressee	Each person is individually called to follow Christ	The decisive subject is the class, society, humanity, or collective true consciousness
Status of the person	The person remains irreducible, morally responsible, and individually related to God	Separate individuality is interpreted as alienation, bourgeois abstraction, or false consciousness to be overcome
Form of unity	One body with many different members, gifts, and functions	Separation overcome in an increasingly comprehensive collective subject
Source of consciousness	The Holy Spirit comes from God, dwells in persons, and is not generated by crowd synchrony	True consciousness is historically and socially enacted through the class or its claimed representatives
Ultimate center	Christ and a kingdom not reducible to terrestrial power	The emancipated earthly collective and its transformed material order

Dimension	Christian differentiated-unity architecture above the anti-Babel floor	Marxist subjecthood-absorption (fusion) pole as reconstructed here
Jurisdiction	Religious and temporal authority can be distinguished; neither straightforwardly owns the whole person	Political, economic, cultural, and epistemic authority tend toward integration under one emancipatory programme
Ownership	No stealing and no coveting protect an owner; gift and stewardship regulate ownership	Bourgeois productive property is to be abolished and converted into common power; personal appropriation for life is not thereby necessarily abolished
Disagreement	A person can appeal beyond church and state to God, conscience, scripture, and truth	Dissent can be interpreted as false consciousness, class betrayal, or resistance to emancipation
Characteristic image	Many members, one body	The originating far-end image: drops of water in one clear pond

This is a **Culture Mechanics interpretation**, not a neutral synopsis of all Christianity or Marxism. In chapter II of Marx and Engels's *Manifest der Kommunistischen Partei*, the defining demand is abolition of bourgeois private property, not abolition of all personal appropriation; the text also ends by making the free development of each the condition for the free development of all. Those are real boundaries on the strongest subjecthood-absorption (fusion) reading. The reconstruction instead asks what happens when abolition of private productive jurisdiction, class consciousness, centralized transition, and the aspiration to overcome alienation are combined into one operative mythology. Its detailed ownership mechanism appears later in "Enlightenment architecture and collectivist counter-construction".

The deepest contrast proposed here is therefore not "community versus no community." Christianity and Marxism both promise unity and mutual obligation. The contrast is where the absolute is located and whether the earthly collective may claim the whole person. Christianity locates the absolute beyond the terrestrial collective and thereby preserves a possible point of resistance to it. The subjecthood-absorption reading of Marxism relocates the absolute into historical society and tends to treat independent judgment, ownership, and loyalty as residues to be overcome.

Marxism is the paradigmatic contrast in this story, not the only possible fusion ideology. Nationalist, fascist, technocratic, and ponerogenically captured religious systems can also seek to absorb personal judgment and jurisdiction. The diagnostic is subjecthood absorption and its fusion pressures, not the movement's preferred label.

5.9 Ponerogenic capture, distortion, and historical countercases

Christianity is not immune to capture. In Andrew M. Łobaczewski's *Political Ponerology*, religious associations can undergo a ponerogenic process: pathological actors can appropriate an organization, subordinate it to goals foreign to its originating idea, and use deformed theological or moral language to disguise domination. He also argues that religious conviction and organization can become sources of resistance to pathocracy. The two possibilities must be kept together.

The originating judgment is:

> **Christianity can be institutionally captured, politically weaponized, and converted into a mythology of worldly power. But it is not well suited to total subjecthood absorption (total fusion) in its proper form, because the captor must neutralize or invert its internal protections of differentiated persons, transcendent judgment, bounded worldly authority, and ownership.**

In ponerological terms, a captured institution can retain Christian names while its operative mythology changes. "Body of Christ" can be flattened from many members into compulsory sameness; spiritual authority can be identified with a particular ruler or bureaucracy; a kingdom not of this world can be converted into an imperial programme; confession can become surveillance; charity can become compulsory surrender to administrators. Those possibilities are not exonerated as Christian merely because Christian symbols remain installed on the façade.

That defense can become circular if every Christian atrocity is defined away as "not true Christianity." The proposal therefore needs historical tests. It gains support if Christian critics repeatedly use the individual call, differentiated

body, transcendent judgment, bounded kingdom, or protected neighbor to resist subjecthood absorption and coercion from within their own tradition. It weakens if those elements do not constrain institutions, if total fusion follows just as directly from the core texts, or if purportedly person-preserving Christian institutions are no less likely to erase persons and jurisdictions than relevant alternatives.

Durkheim's genealogy is not an immunity claim. It identifies individualizing tendencies within Christianity and treats modern Humanism as their continuation; it does not show that every church embodied them or that opposing tendencies were external intrusions. Historical coercion, confessional supremacy, fused ecclesiastical and political jurisdiction, punishment of inquiry, and suppression of conscience remain counterevidence whose relation to the load-bearing Christian architecture must be investigated rather than defined away.

The distinction to test is among **the normative architecture reconstructed here**, **historical Christian institutions**, and **ponerogenically captured successors using Christian language**. None can substitute automatically for the others. The historical claim is not that Christianity always produced liberal individualism. It is that Christianity contained a distinctive person-preserving, anti-fusion architecture which, together with its kinship intervention and later regional conditions, helped make such a development possible.

6. The Rhine corridor: jurisdictional parallax and the double edge of print

The falling-cost story can sound one-directional: a medium reproduces one mythology more cheaply, expands its reach, and helps synchronize a larger population. The Rhine supplies a second possibility. The same infrastructure can carry rival orders across their boundaries, place their incompatible answers within one field of observation, and thereby weaken each order's ability to present its own first-order rules as simply identical with reality.

6.1 Miniter's originating scene

The immediate provenance of this picture is Richard Miniter's interview, *The Best Conversation About News, Opinion and Censorship You've Ever Heard*, published by TRIGGERnometry on 21 January 2026. Beginning at approximately 09:27, Miniter imagines a traveler moving down the Rhine through a patchwork of principalities and confessions. A person can remain on the river, see a city governed by an incompatible confession, and know that landing there might expose person or cargo to a very different legal and religious order. Printing at Mainz, river transport, commercial demand, confessional rivalry, and reports about conditions in other cities then combine into a competitive news ecology. A searchable third-party transcript helps locate the passage; the interview itself is the source.

Miniter interprets this ecology as one source of Protestant and Dutch toleration, independent news, free expression, and accountability to readers. The present synthesis narrows that conclusion: the ecology creates opportunities and pressures for comparison and toleration, but does not by itself establish their origin or make them inevitable.

Source interpretation: Miniter's scene is memorable because it compresses the structural relationship among transport, jurisdiction, confession, print, commerce, and toleration. It is not a reliable literal chronology. He folds roughly a century and a half of developments into one story and assigns some later practices to Gutenberg's own period.

The picture must therefore be uncompressed:

Period	Better-supported development
Mid-fifteenth century	Gutenberg's workshop develops European movable-type printing at Mainz. The 42-line Bible was printed in Latin and completed around 1455; the Gutenberg information service of the City of Mainz documents both the language and the printing dispute that followed.
Early sixteenth century	Reformation polemics make printing a major vehicle for competing confessional programmes. Gutenberg, who died in 1468, could not have printed tracts for later Protestant denominations.
1555 and after	The Peace of Augsburg enables princes to require conformity or emigration and permits cities to tolerate the Lutheran confession; Reformed Christianity receives recognition in 1648. The resulting patchwork is summarized in *Confessional Divisions (c. 1560)*.

Period	Better-supported development
Late sixteenth century	Manuscript newsletters, pamphlets, postal routes, and the *Messrelationen* sold at fairs already support recurrent transregional news.
1605	Johann Carolus begins the periodical printed newspaper at Strasbourg. Johannes Weber's "Strassburg, 1605: The Origins of the Newspaper in Europe" connects printing, relay posts, correspondents, periodicity, and a widening political public.
Seventeenth century	Newspapers spread through the Holy Roman Empire and draw reports from hubs including Cologne, Amsterdam, Venice, Paris, Vienna, and Rome. Jan Hillgärtner reconstructs this network in *The German Newspaper in Its First Years of Existence*.
1605–1650	Netherlandish reports become important to German coverage, while some durable German publishers adapt business models developed in the Northern and Southern Netherlands. This reciprocal influence is traced in Jan Hillgärtner's "Netherlandish Reports in German Newspapers, 1605–1650". It supports a connected news ecology, not a claim of unrestricted Dutch toleration.

Miniter's "Gutenberg prints Protestant newsbooks" is therefore false if read as an event. Read as a compressed systems diagram, however, the scene directs attention to a defensible sequence: printing begins at Mainz; confessional fragmentation multiplies rival programmes; trade and postal routes carry material among cities; and periodical news later makes their differences recurrently observable.

6.2 The historical substrate: a corridor through a patchwork

The Rhine was not merely a line on a map. It connected cities, markets, ports, printers, postal routes, travelers, rulers, and religious communities. The Holy Roman Empire supplied no single uniform jurisdiction along that route. Political disintegration and territorial structure shaped the differentiated German news landscape, while imperial control of the market remained much weaker than control available to more centralized states; see the historical analysis in "Globalizing the Thirty Years War: Early German Newspapers and their Geopolitical Perspective on the Atlantic World".

Sabine Baring-Gould's *A Book of the Rhine from Cleve to Mainz* (1906) later described the historical region as a "hodge-podge of authorities and conflicting interests." In one heavily partitioned area, he observed, "a little brook divides parishes and religions." This is a retrospective travel history, not proof of Miniter's entire causal account, but it preserves the visible geography of the jurisdictional patchwork.

Persecution within that landscape was real, and Protestants persecuted other Protestants as well as being persecuted by Catholic authorities. Miniter's picture of remaining safe in the current but risking being burned upon landing should nevertheless remain a vivid originating scene, not a general legal rule. Danger varied with period, territory, confession, status, alleged offense, and local enforcement. The formal alternative after Augsburg was often conformity or emigration; imprisonment, confiscation, expulsion, and execution require concrete cases rather than one uniform Rhine-wide probability.

6.3 Jurisdictional parallax

Project synthesis: This narrative proposes **jurisdictional parallax** for the change in appearance produced when movement or communication places incompatible jurisdictions within one field of observation:

> **When the same conduct appears obligatory in one jurisdiction, forbidden in the next, and irrelevant in a third, first-order rules become visible as locally installed cultural programmes rather than self-evident features of reality.**

The term names an observational mechanism, not a guarantee of emancipation. A person formed entirely within one living first-order order may experience its answers as the structure of the world: this act is sacred, that act is polluting, this authority is naturally entitled to rule, and no decent person could classify the matter differently. Travel can reveal that another community's local bigOther returns a contradictory answer with equal confidence and spiritual attachment.

Printing and newspapers make such border crossing partly cognitive. Reports from several jurisdictions can arrive in one city or appear in one periodical. A reader need not enter every territory to learn that different populations inhabit different moral, legal, and sacred realities.

The possible cognitive result is **comparative denaturalization**:

```
one inherited first-order order
-> its rules feel identical with reality

incompatible neighboring orders become jointly observable
-> their authorship, boundaries, and jurisdictions become visible

visible contingency
-> demand for rules governing coexistence among different orders
```

"Contingent" does not mean pointless, false, or morally worthless. An inherited rule may encode experience, solve a coordination problem, or remain substantively right. Jurisdictional parallax defeats only the inference that a rule must be universally necessary because one local field makes it feel self-evident. It turns the rule and its claim to jurisdiction into possible objects of judgment.

6.4 From parallax to lifted mechanical solidarity

Repeated observation of incompatible first-order orders creates a practical problem. If populations cannot agree about the correct confession, worship, calendar, dress, family discipline, or comprehensive way of life, one substantive answer can govern the whole space only through conversion, expulsion, segregation, or coercion. Peaceful cooperation instead requires shared rules about how different answers are generated, bounded, recognized, contested, and changed.

The proposed pressure is therefore:

```
jurisdictional parallax
+ recurrent commerce and communication across boundaries
+ failure of one confession to eliminate all rivals
-> pressure for toleration and bounded jurisdiction
-> possible lifting of shared binding force
```

The resulting meta-order may protect freedom of conscience, legitimate disagreement, contract, property, impersonal law, due process, peaceful exit, and institutional succession. In Culture Mechanics these are not an absence of mechanical solidarity. They can become objects of **lifted mechanical solidarity**: shared binding force moves from an inherited corpus of concrete answers to rules for producing, limiting, coordinating, and correcting answers. Such lifting can permit plural first-order outputs and bounded jurisdictions, but plurality is a possible consequence rather than the definition. The authoritative distinction is stated under mechanical solidarity, and its boundary cases remain in "Examples, cases, and boundary tests" in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*.

In the newer vocabulary, the historical claim is that these changes can increase both **effective meta-order thickness**—more usable shared rules for translation, jurisdiction, disagreement, loss, and succession—and **meta-order span**—more persons, institutions, domains, and interfaces recognizing those rules. Their effective shared surface supports cultural interoperability above the anti-Babel floor. A paper constitution without operative recognition would be only a nominal lifted meta-order and would not perform that work.

The chronological distinction matters here. In *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology*, Kenneth Minogue calls Burckhardt's account of Renaissance Italy "swarming with individuality" a famous example. Jacob Burckhardt's original work is *Die Cultur der Renaissance in Italien: ein Versuch* (1860). The phrase describes a visible phenotype—many differentiated persons—not by itself the later philosophical doctrine of individualism or the project's separate hypothesis about individualist dispositions. The Rhine mechanism therefore need not originate the individual. It may help make competing forms of life mutually visible and create pressure for institutions that recognize and protect bounded personal jurisdictions. The prior Christian differentiated-unity architecture supplies one proposed

religious grammar for remaining above the cultural-interoperability floor (anti-Babel floor) without subjecthood absorption; jurisdictional parallax and later institutions supply a different mechanism by which that possibility could become visible, contested, and legally protected.

Three terms must remain distinct:

Term	Role in the proposed history
Individuality	The visible phenotype: numerous persons acting as differentiated centers of judgment, ambition, reputation, style, and agency.
Individualism	The mythology and institutional order that legitimates those persons and protects their jurisdictions.
Individualist disposition	A proposed psychological—and possibly partly heritable—propensity that makes such an order feel attractive, intelligible, or natural.

Originating hypothesis: Northern Italy and the Rhine do not explain how the possibility of individualism entered an otherwise uniform Europe. They help explain why a much longer Western transformation became concentrated, visible, defended, and self-reinforcing in particular regions. The proposed sequence is:

Period	Proposed development
Late antiquity and Middle Ages	Western Christian marriage-and-family rules weaken intensive kinship and widen reproductive, social, and mythological networks.
High and late Middle Ages	Towns, guilds, monasteries, universities, trade, impersonal law, and voluntary associations reward action beyond one closed clan.
Northern Italian Renaissance	Dense commercial cities—possibly especially Venice—make autonomous, mobile, self-fashioning persons sufficiently numerous to become visible "by eye."
Northwestern corridor	Commercial, ecclesiastical, intellectual, and later printing networks connect northern Italy across the Alps with the Rhine, Low Countries, and Britain.
Around 1500	The cumulative phenotype appears astonishing: Renaissance Italy is described as "swarming with individuality."
Seventeenth and eighteenth centuries	Enlightenment thinkers name, defend, systematize, and further institutionalize an individual-sovereignty order already emerging around them.

This makes the Rhine corridor a proposed **regional selector and amplifier**, not a single origin point. Mobility, trade, fragmented authority, confessional rivalry, and print created unusually strong rewards for stranger cooperation while making the boundedness of first-order rules unusually hard to ignore. Existing dispositions could be expressed more strongly; individualistically disposed people could migrate into commercial cities; institutions could train individual conduct; and successful persons could acquire status, partners, and influence. Only some of those pathways could contribute to directional genetic change. The separately inspectable genetic extension is developed in "The genetic-hardware auxiliary hypothesis".

6.5 The double edge of print

The same medium can produce opposite crowd effects because medium, message, and network topology are not identical:

Communication ecology	Possible Culture Mechanics effect
One dominant mythology, repeated widely while counter-signals are suppressed	Stronger common attention, doctrinal standardization, and possible laser synchronization
Rival confessional presses without an operative shared meta-order above the anti-Babel floor	Faster polemics, harder boundaries, mutual demonization, and violent ideological conflict
Reports from several jurisdictions made mutually observable	Jurisdictional parallax, comparative denaturalization, and cognitive distance from the inherited answer
Plural publications governed by shared lifted rules	Clockwork coordination, criticism among differentiated sources, and corrigible public reasoning

Print therefore does not possess an intrinsically liberating or collectivizing essence. Centralized control can turn it into a cheap missionary for one mythology. A fragmented polemical market can generate several hostile laser domains. A plural and protected ecology can reveal alternatives, preserve counter-signals, and help people judge their own inherited programming. Its direction depends upon ownership, censorship, competition, trust, literacy, distribution, jurisdiction, and the rules governing conflict among speakers.

This symmetry modifies—but does not cancel—the falling-cost hypothesis. Printing made the reproduction of a multi-mind-self cheaper. It also made competing multi-mind-selves cheaper and more mutually observable. The first effect can increase synchronization; the second can produce rivalry, cultural interoperability breakdown (Babelization), or the second-order perspective needed for lifted coexistence.

6.6 Boundaries and open tests

The Rhine proposal remains a historical mechanism hypothesis rather than a demonstrated monocausal explanation.

- Political and confessional fragmentation can produce war, censorship, and local tyranny rather than toleration.
- Exposure to alternatives can harden dogmatism instead of producing cognitive liberty.
- Commercial interest can encourage a printer to carry rival material without the printer believing in free speech as a moral principle.
- Newspaper reading can synchronize an imagined public around one agenda even while exposing readers to several places.
- Similar lifted developments outside the Rhine corridor would show that the proposed mechanism is portable rather than geographically unique; earlier cases could move the chronology backward.
- Evidence that readers treated foreign reports only as curiosities or enemy propaganda, without reflecting on their own jurisdiction, would weaken the comparative-denaturalization step.

The strongest version of the hypothesis predicts more than print circulation. It predicts traces of comparison: arguments that explicitly juxtapose jurisdictions, recognize the contingency of inherited rules, defend bounded authority, or move binding force from a particular first-order answer to a rule of toleration, procedure, or correction. Those traces must be found rather than inferred merely from the presence of a printing press.

7. Around 1700: a proposed takeoff

Originating hypothesis: The combination of idealist philosophers, printing, and increasingly available newspapers began an upward spiral of modern Culture Mechanics around 1700, or somewhat earlier.

The date is a research marker, not a discovered breakpoint. Movable-type printing was already centuries old in Europe, the Reformation had demonstrated its power, and early newspapers preceded 1700. The hypothesis is therefore not “printing began in 1700.” It is that several elements may then have crossed a joint threshold:

```
weakening inherited religious and corporate bonds
+ expanding literate publics
+ recurrent print and political news
+ philosophical construction of total social explanations
+ growing state and commercial distribution capacity
-> a new regime for secular mass mythology
```

Kenneth Minogue’s *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology* is a major source for the project’s interpretation of modern ideology. In the reading used here, Minogue describes a modern nightmare: individualism dissolves social

bonds into selfish, competing atoms, while ideology offers a revelation that the apparently free order is actually systematic oppression and therefore demands transformation.

Stephen Hicks's *Explaining Postmodernism: Skepticism and Socialism from Rousseau to Foucault* supplies a more partisan genealogy of Enlightenment and Counter-Enlightenment. Hicks presents reason and individualism as joined in the Enlightenment and reads Rousseau, German idealism, and later collectivist traditions as reacting against that settlement.

Source-interpretation caution: Neither Minogue nor Hicks is a neutral census of the history of ideas. Hicks's placement of Rousseau, Kant, Hegel, socialism, and postmodernism in one Counter-Enlightenment lineage is contested. Their works are used here because they articulate the exact fear and reaction that the project is trying to model. Their genealogies must be checked against primary texts and rival histories before being treated as established.

Originating hypothesis: Thinkers distressed by individualism and social quarreling may have *stumbled upon* the construction grammar of modern mythology. This need not imply a conspiracy or full conscious understanding. A thinker can select formulations that recruit, moralize, synchronize, and reproduce because those formulations survive and mobilize, without possessing an explicit theory of the mechanism. Later thinkers and organizations can then observe the effects and refine the technology more deliberately.

The phrase "reverse engineered the mechanisms of storytelling and mythology" should therefore cover a range:

Mode	Degree of awareness
Expressive discovery	The author says what feels true and discovers that it resonates.
Cultural selection	Memorable, identity-bearing, and mobilizing variants spread more successfully.
Craft knowledge	Writers and organizers learn practical rhetorical and ritual techniques without a general theory.
Explicit engineering	Institutions deliberately test messages, audiences, channels, sanctions, and feedback.

The first two modes are enough to start an upward spiral. Conscious engineering can arrive later.

The distinction is now explicit in the authoritative theory. **Endogenous mythology formation** is the ordinary growth path: changes in structure, institutions, practice, and receivers create mismatches and aspirations; competing articulations are selected and embodied without one author choosing the final order. **Purposive mythology construction** is the open research possibility that an actor can choose a proposed destination (D^*), diagnose the likely baseline, and deliberately alter mythologies and supporting arrangements in an attempt to bend the trajectory. Deliberate interventions plainly occur; how far they can reliably construct the released successor remains open.

```
endogenous course:
conditions → receiver-order mismatch → articulations
→ distributed selection → embodiment

prospective purposive redirection:
chosen D* → baseline and receiver diagnosis
→ mythology + system intervention → feedback and revision
```

A plant image makes the distinction visible. Naturally grown mythology can branch, hybridize, and be selected without a gardener; studying that growth is a substantive project, not merely preparation for design. A prospective constructor may cultivate, prune, graft, or attempt replacement, but remains inside the same ecology. The intended plant is not necessarily the one that survives.

James Gardner's 1996 popular essay "Memetic Engineering" is a late, unusually explicit statement of the control ambition: manipulate interacting cultural replicators in order to produce a deliberately altered cultural result. It is useful provenance, not proof that such a science exists. The present story retains the warning that a programme can reproduce at its carriers' expense and the possibility that actors can deliberately modify selection. It rejects the inference that memes alone explain consciousness or that culture can be controlled with genetic-engineering precision.

Where purposive construction is attempted, the actual successor remains jointly selected:

```
intended destination × receivers × incumbent order × institutions
× rivals × unintended consequences × reality
→ actual successor
```

This boundary matters historically. Evidence of a mobilizing doctrine does not by itself show an engineer; evidence of an engineer does not show command of the outcome.

Durkheim supplies a second and more retrospective test. In "Individualism and the Intellectuals" (1898), translated by Mark Traugott in *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society*, pp. 43–57, he proposes assessing doctrines through what they produce and through the character of the doctrines born from them. The authoritative semantic definition preserves his exact formulation.

Durkheim's own examples are Kantianism giving rise to Fichte's ethics and to Hegel, "of whom Marx was the disciple," and Rousseauian individualism combining with an authoritarian conception of society and revolutionary French centralization. His point is not that Kant and Rousseau were merely egoists. It is that their universal moral individualism contained a strong supra-individual and collective potential disclosed by its successors.

The originating project takes this maxim further:

> **Do not judge a doctrine only by the sentences its CPU-facing surface invites you to endorse. Inspect the bigOther machinery and institutions it activates, and inspect the offspring to which that complete implementation gives birth.**

This becomes the **doctrinal-progeny test**. Its **offspring profile** is a distribution, not one notorious child or one carefully selected success. Its **generative spirit** is the recurrent direction produced by explicit semantics, implicit subjecthood and authority grammar, receiver architecture, interpreters, institutions, incentives, power, rivals, and conditions.

A descendant can be entailed, merely afforded or authorized, selected among several possible readings, concealed in an undisclosed implementation, or produced through appropriation and inversion. These relations carry different burdens. The originating correction to the usual genealogy is deliberately accusatory:

> **If a doctrine tells the CPU what it wants to hear but knowingly relies on undisclosed bigOther machinery to produce a broader or different result, the omission belongs to the doctrine's responsibility. It is a kind of lying by omission.**

The moral verdict requires evidence. Private strategy, audience segmentation, institutional design, predictions made before implementation, repeated effects, and refusal to disclose after the mechanism becomes visible can support it. Hindsight, family resemblance, and one bad descendant cannot. Shared organizational templates and geopolitical pressures can also make several implementations less independent than a list of countries suggests.

8. The God-shaped hole and successor mythologies

The originating story interprets the modern transition as more than intellectual fashion. Traditional European mythologies and solidarities lost part of their binding force. Individualism, commerce, science, mobility, and legal abstraction made inherited roles less total. Some people welcomed emancipation; others felt social unraveling and the ache of a **God-shaped hole**.

This image already has two different statuses inside Culture Mechanics. As a Christian interpretation, the longing for ultimate belonging, orientation, and transcendence is directed toward God rather than toward an earthly collective claiming the whole person. Christianity can sustain a shared culture and even a church-level multi-mind-self while refusing the total-fusion claim; the distinction is developed in "Christianity: differentiated unity without fusion". As a secular mechanism hypothesis, the weakening of one living mythology can leave a population receptive to successor packages that restore belonging, sacredness, direction, and sacrifice.

This is not necessarily a story of an old multi-mind-self lying dormant. A culture can forget how to produce the earlier state. Its rules may survive as affectively dead customs and detached symbols. Modern nationalism or revolutionary ideology may then be a **newly constructed successor system**, not merely Christianity or traditional community reactivated under another name. The calm-period ambiguity between dormancy, de-animation, cultural loss, and successor construction is developed in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*, "Observability, cultural forgetting, and contemporary witnesses".

9. Enlightenment architecture and collectivist counter-construction

The originating interpretation draws a sharp contrast.

On one side, Enlightenment and liberal traditions developed what this project retroactively calls the **individual-sovereignty technology suite**: property, contract, markets, rights, rule of law, impersonal office, scientific criticism, and institutions that allow strangers with different purposes to coordinate. Calling some of these "anonymous strategy-proof mechanisms" is a modern game-theoretic analogy, not a claim that eighteenth-century thinkers used that term or that actual markets and legal systems are perfectly strategy-proof.

The suite aims at a clockwork form of social intelligence:

```
shared lifted rules
+ bounded jurisdictions
+ different local purposes
+ division of labor and reality correction
-> coordinated social gains without one substantive group mind
```

The originating story treats these culture-strategies as weakly coupled to reality in the short run but capable of **compound-interest effects** across decades or centuries. The advantage of one rule over another may be nearly invisible in a single encounter while eventually producing very different knowledge, trust, prosperity, or failure. That slow payoff is one reason vivid first-order mythologies can defeat good lifted mechanisms politically: the mythology supplies an immediate feeling and enemy, while the mechanism asks people to protect an abstract process whose return arrives later.

On the other side, the originating verdict is deliberately strong:

> **Marxism and its leftist descendants seek to abolish the individual so that society becomes a single giant true consciousness.**

This is not presented as a neutral description accepted by all Marxists or all people on the political left. It is the framework's judgment about programs that classify individual sovereignty as alienation or false consciousness and migrate binding authority from persons and plural institutions into a collectively enacted first-order truth. The image of people becoming "drops of water in a clear pond" preserves the intended contrast: personal opacity, jurisdiction, and rivalry are replaced by imagined social transparency.

In that originating vocabulary, Marxian **false consciousness** is read as a cultural strategy running as a program in the big Other, while *capitalism* often functions polemically as a name for the individual-sovereignty technology suite. This is the project's translation of ideological language into its own architecture, not Marx's definition of either term.

Rousseau's analytic common core and Durkheim's constructed Humanity

The originating phrase **"the I without the me"** names an attempted removal of indexical private position:

```
"me"
= my appetite, advantage, biography, class, caste,
  passion, attachment, and privileged location

"I without the me"
= what remains when a rule, will, or standing
  no longer depends upon those private coordinates
```

This is not the bare phenomenological subject and not a claim that persons become psychologically interchangeable. It asks whether something impersonal can remain after the authority of *my* particular position has been removed. Rousseau and Durkheim perform two fundamentally different operations upon that question.

Rousseau: analytic, extractive, or estimative Durkheim describes Rousseau's general will as an "impersonal average" in which divergent individual considerations neutralize one another. That is Durkheim's compressed interpretation, not the whole of Rousseau's theory. Rousseau does not define the general will as whatever a poll happens to average; he distinguishes the will of all from the common-interest orientation of the general will and warns that factions can prevent the required independence. See Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, book II, chapter 3.

The reconstructed operation is nevertheless analytic:

```
will_1 = common civic component L + particular deviation p_1
will_2 = common civic component L + particular deviation p_2
will_3 = common civic component L + particular deviation p_3
...

aggregate sufficiently independent wills
→ particular deviations cancel
→ common component L becomes visible
→ L is treated as the general will
```

The common core is presumed to be a signal already present inside living persons. Aggregation estimates or extracts it. In the earlier approximation language, Rousseau's model becomes plausible if people share a large zeroth- or first-order civic core while their private differences are smaller, non-systematic, and sufficiently independent.

The assumptions are demanding:

- a real common-interest component must exist;
- particular deviations must not dominate it;
- citizens must form judgments independently enough for deviations to cancel;
- factions, shared misinformation, intimidation, and strategic coordination must not create correlated error;
- and the process must not have been programmed upstream to recover a conclusion already installed by the legislator.

The last danger is distinctively culture-mechanical:

```
lawgiver or formative institutions install L
→ L becomes common bigOther programming
→ individual deviations cancel around L
→ aggregation recovers L
→ the recovered programme is declared the authentic will of the people
```

The procedure can then mistake successful cultural construction for independent discovery. What is common does not cancel. A shared bigOther programme is correlated across citizens and therefore survives averaging as if it were unprogrammed Humanity. This connects the analytic problem directly to Rousseau's extraordinary legislator and to the *Herrschaftsideologie* risk developed below.

Durkheim: constructive and idealizing Durkheim begins from the opposite historical diagnosis. Expanding society and division of labour have made people increasingly different, so no sufficiently rich empirical personality remains common to everyone. His Humanism therefore does not average many personalities into a representative person. It constructs the **human person in general**, assigns every concrete person standing as an instance, and culturally sacralizes that standing. See "Individualism and the Intellectuals," pp. 48 and 51–54.

The geometry analogy preserves the originating intuition:

Pure geometry	Durkheimian Humanism
Every physical circle has material, thickness, irregularity, and a location.	Every real person has a body, biography, disposition, culture, capabilities, interests, and peculiarities.
Geometry disregards those contingent physical properties.	Humanism disregards those contingent differences when assigning basic standing.
The ideal circle is not the statistical average of physical circles.	Humanity is not the average personality or the empirically typical person.
The ideal supplies a common rule for recognizing circles.	The human-person abstraction supplies a common rule for recognizing inviolable standing.

A geometrical circle is constructed by specifying an invariant relation rather than by averaging approximately circular objects. Likewise, the Durkheimian human person is an ideal form or normative abstraction, not a statistical composite:

```
radically different concrete persons
→ disregard contingent personal and cultural characteristics
→ formulate "the human person in general"
```

```
→ assign complete standing to every concrete instance
→ sacralize and institutionally protect that standing
```

"Durkheim invents Humanity" must be bounded carefully. Durkheim does not claim that he personally fabricated the human person from nothing. His sociological claim is that modern society historically constructs and sacralizes this common object as older common contents dissolve. Durkheim identifies, articulates, and defends the construction.

Decision source versus decision constraint The difference can be compressed:

```
Rousseau:
empirical wills
→ remove or cancel particular deviations
→ infer the common will
→ "This is what we truly will."

Durkheim:
construct the human person in general
→ assign sacred standing to every concrete person
→ constrain collective outputs
→ "No collective output may consume this person."
```

Rousseau's extracted common core becomes a **source of collective decisions**. Durkheim's constructed common human becomes primarily a **constraint upon decisions**. The contrast becomes decisive at the outlier. Rousseauian averaging can classify a minority of one as a deviation to be cancelled. Durkheimian Humanism can say that the most statistically exceptional person still completely instantiates human standing.

The compact formulation is:

> **Rousseau searches for the common signal inside empirical wills. Durkheim constructs an ideal coordinate system within which otherwise incomparable persons acquire equal standing.**

Humanism as installed mythology The constructive claim is stronger than philosophical abstraction. If people are different even at the zeroth-order approximation, universal standing may not emerge spontaneously from perceived similarity. Society may have to teach, persuade, or *einreden* people into experiencing every stranger and outlier as a complete bearer of sacred Humanity:

```
stories and exemplary cases
+ declarations of rights
+ schools and moral education
+ courts visibly protecting unpopular persons
+ public rituals, memorials, and sanctions
+ institutions treating strangers as equal rights-bearers
→ local bigOthers learn:
  "an attack upon this concrete person profanes Humanity"
```

This is mythology construction in the neutral project sense. The proposed Humanist mythology should not depend upon the empirically brittle story that people are fundamentally alike:

> **However profoundly different human beings are, every concrete person is to be treated as a complete bearer of sacred standing.**

Three truth questions must remain separate:

1. **Empirical sameness:** humans possess approximately the same capabilities, dispositions, experiences, or form of reason. This is a testable description and is false if psychologically important differences reach the zeroth order.
2. **Normative standing:** those differences do not authorize treating a person merely as material, arbitrarily ruling the person, or sacrificing the person to an aggregate. This is a constituted axiom, not the output of an average.
3. **Constituted social reality:** every person actually possesses protected standing in this society. This becomes socially real when the living mythology and institutional skeleton make it operative in conduct, law, appeal, and correction.

The construction must remain tied to each concrete person. Otherwise **Humanity inversion** can occur: Humanity is agentified, officials claim access to its alleged true interest, and concrete humans are sacrificed for the abstraction

supposedly created to protect them. The geometric analogy also stops here. A circle does not contest its definition; Humanity remains interpreted, disputed, institutionally embodied, and vulnerable to capture.

This produces an empirical discriminator between the two operations. When an unpopular or radically atypical person conflicts with an asserted collective will, does the order cancel the outlier as noise, or does the person's standing constrain the aggregate? The answer reveals whether "Humanity" functions as a decision source above persons or as a person-preserving limit upon power.

Rousseau's legislator and *Herrschaftsideologie*

The originating judgment about Rousseau is intentionally sharp:

> **This is a *Herrschafts-Mythologie*: a system constructed around the exceptional person who can form the others and thereby occupy the position from which they are ruled.**

Rousseau's *Social Contract*, book II, chapter 7, calls for an "extraordinary" legislator capable of changing human nature and giving a people its formative institutions. Rousseau also restricts that figure: the legislator does not possess legislative sovereignty and cannot simply command the laws into force. That boundary matters. Yet the asymmetry remains striking in Culture Mechanics terms: someone outside the ordinary citizen role diagnoses the people, designs the framework that will form their sentiments, and knows what they are not yet able to will as a people.

Rousseau's own outlier status makes the picture psychologically provocative. The originating interpretation is that the exceptional author imagines a system in which exceptional insight is precisely what qualifies a person for the formative position. This is not proof of conscious self-coronation. The rival interpretations are that Rousseau was solving a genuine founding problem, describing a constitutional function rather than himself, or constructing an ideal type whose authority he explicitly tried to limit. The self-legitimation hypothesis would need biographical, textual, and reception evidence rather than laughter at the fit alone.

The general construct is ***Herrschaftsideologie***: a mythology through which a person, class, office, or institution experiences exceptional authority as justified by privileged access to truth, morality, historical necessity, or a collective's hidden interest. The originating claim puts the psychological order first:

> **The story legitimizes the ruler to himself first and to the ruled second.**

The **X-ray-vision** and **secular-gnosis** analogies name its epistemic grammar. The enlightened interpreter sees a reality ordinary people cannot see. Their expressed preferences can therefore be dismissed as ignorance, immaturity, selfishness, or false consciousness. Why deliberate with a person who allegedly cannot perceive the full situation and cannot be made to perceive it? The epistemic distinction becomes a rank distinction, and the rank distinction becomes jurisdiction:

```
agentified People, History, Humanity, Nation, Science, or Class
                              ↓
true interest inaccessible to ordinary members
                              ↓
exceptional interpreter with "X-ray vision"
                              ↓
claimed knowledge becomes authority over the unseeing
                              ↓
disagreement confirms blindness
                              ↓
coercion becomes education, protection, necessity, or liberation
                              ↓
failure calls for more faithful interpretation or more control
```

The press-secretary mechanism need not invent a cynical cover from nothing. Mission, fear, status, material benefit, and attraction to control can be experienced together and verbalized as necessary guardianship. Sincerity does not make the jurisdiction valid; material advantage does not prove conscious fraud. The discriminating question is whether the claimed knowledge is evidence-answerable and whether its holder remains bounded, contestable, removable, and corrigible.

Party-state implementations and the plantation analogy The originating application concerns observable communist and Marxist implementations–among them the Soviet Union, Cuba, and North Korea–rather than a dictionary

exercise about ideal doctrine:

> **Again and again, "the people" nominally rule while a small interpreter-owner group governs the masses, controls the productive base, restricts exit, and lives from everybody else's compelled labour. In the harsh analogy, the result resembles a plantation.**

This formulation is preserved as an originating verdict, not laundered into a neutral institutional euphemism. Its separate claims require separate evidence. Milovan Djilas's *The New Class* argued from inside the Yugoslav communist movement that the political bureaucracy "uses, enjoys, and disposes of nationalized property." His position is *Zeitzeugnis*: situatedness creates access, not calibration. Memory, interpretation, personal conflict, representativeness, and corroboration remain separate questions. A World Bank historical study of Russian civil-service reform documents the Soviet *nomenklatura* system and its rigidly graded privileges. For Cuba, Louis Thiemann and Claudia González Marrero report that the Communist Party outlawed virtually all non-state labour and exchange from 1968 to 1993. The UN Human Rights Office's 2024 report describes institutionalized forced labour in North Korea, including a system beginning at school.

These sources support concrete parts of the institutional pattern; they do not by themselves prove a single doctrine-to-outcome cause, equal conditions across countries, or the complete plantation analogy. War, poverty, sanctions, state capacity, inherited autocracy, leaders, geopolitics, and a shared Soviet organizational template are rival or interacting causes. Nor are the cases independent replications merely because they carry different national names.

The doctrinal-progeny question nevertheless remains legitimate. Recurrent party monopoly, concentrated economic control, a privileged administrative stratum, restricted exit, compelled labour, suppressed opposition, and blocked correction are evidence about an offspring profile. They cannot be dismissed automatically by renaming every adverse descendant "not real communism." The serious audit asks whether these outcomes were entailed, afforded, selected by the doctrine's implementation ecology, knowingly concealed, or imported through appropriation and external conditions. It must also search for counterexamples: communist or Marxist-descended orders that preserve independent opposition, property or robust functional substitutes, genuine exit, bounded interpreters, succession, and reality's right of correction.

This theory is not left-specific. Priests, monarchs, national leaders, technocrats, corporations, therapists, scientists, military guardians, or countercultural elites can tell the same privileged-vision story. The error is not "some people know more." It is:

> **I know something you do not; therefore I possess jurisdiction over you.**

Communist ownership as ownership by one collective subject

The ownership theory makes the originating interpretation more intelligible than an account confined to redistribution:

> **Communist ownership is not necessarily imagined as many individuals jointly owning fractions of everything. It can be understood as one collective subject owning through many human organs.**

Private property gives a person a protected jurisdiction from which the person can say: *This is mine; within the law, I may decide what happens here without first obtaining the collective's permission.* If the desired social ontology is instead one true collective consciousness, that private jurisdiction becomes anomalous. It resembles an organ claiming part of the organism against the organism itself. Abolishing private property then changes not merely the distribution of goods but the identity of the owner. It also removes one of the strongest material boundaries from which a differentiated person can resist, preserve memory, and plan a future without continuous collective authorization:

```
private-property order
person -> owns a protected domain -> contracts with other owners

communist true-consciousness order
collective self -> owns the common domain -> allocates its use through human organs
```

Under this reading, alienation is separation of an organ from the collective being whose activity it should enact; false consciousness makes the organ misrecognize a private interest as autonomously its own; class consciousness recognizes the larger subject; and communist ownership becomes the material expression of that subject's true consciousness. The familiar from-each/to-each formula consequently reads more naturally as resource circulation within one organism than as exchange among sovereign owners. This is a **Culture Mechanics reconstruction**. It does not claim that Marx used the term *multi-mind-self* or accepted the present ontology.

The reconstruction also explains why collective legal title is insufficient. The authoritative theory distinguishes legal ownership, organizational agency, and culture-mechanical unitary ownership:

Legal arrangement	Culture-mechanical owner	Predicted condition
Private title	An individual owner	Ordinary private ownership
Collective title	No integrated collective agent	"Nobody's property," free-riding, neglect, or appropriation by administrators
No collective title	A living collective owner	Informal civic stewardship or a customary commons may exist despite the legal form
Collective title	A genuine multi-mind-self	Successful collective ownership is at least theoretically possible

The characteristic failure mode is therefore:

```
property legally assigned to "the people"
+ no sufficiently integrated multi-mind-self actually owns it
+ officials claim authority to represent the absent collective owner
-> practical control by an administrative class
```

In that case communist ownership does not eliminate ownership. It separates nominal ownership from operational control: "the people" remain the mythical owner while party officials, managers, or bureaucratic organs exercise the owner's powers.

Culture Mechanics nevertheless permits real collective ownership of bounded objects—a water system, railway, civic space, institution, enterprise, or shared practice. The possible Marxist insight is therefore not dismissed; the proposed overreach is exposed:

> **Because some goods can be genuinely owned by a collective self, all productive property should be owned by one comprehensive collective self.**

That universalization does not follow from the ownership mechanism. A lifted order can protect private, familial, associational, organizational, civic, and constitutional forms of ownership simultaneously. The communist conclusion needs the additional first-order claim that one collective subject has universal jurisdiction and that individual ownership is illegitimate. In the chimp–bee shorthand, private property is institutionalized **chimp-space**, while communist ownership is institutionalized **bee-space**. The dispute is therefore not only about allocation efficiency; it is a struggle over the identity of the real owner and thus of the real subject. The full mechanism and its boundary conditions remain authoritative in "Unitary ownership by the operative multi-mind-self" in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*.

The same interpretation deliberately disputes the label *progressive*. It calls the collectivist movement **regressive** insofar as its promised higher future restores features of an earlier collective order—unity, common ownership, shared substantive purpose, and diminished individual separation—after the supposed negative passage through modern individualism. Minogue's account of ideological futures modeled upon an idealized past is relevant prior art. Whether a particular movement actually has this temporal structure is an empirical and textual question; the word *regressive* is an originating judgment, not a neutral period label.

The claim must be tested movement by movement and text by text. A self-described left programme that protects independent judgment, property or functional equivalents, institutional succession, lawful opposition, bounded authority, and reality's right of correction would be a counterexample to the generalization. Likewise, nationalist, religious, technocratic, or market-fundamentalist systems can pursue closed first-order capture without being Marxist. The relevant mechanism is not a party label but the location and corrigibility of binding authority.

10. A warning about philosophers—and a defense of *Begriffshandwerk*

The originating warning to the author's children was blunt: beware philosophers. The intuition was that philosophy can employ mathematical or logical form while lacking experimental correction by reality. In its memorable condensed form:

> **Wer hat mir in den Kopf gemacht?**

The source fragment is even more abrasive: “philosophy is mental masturbation,” and the originating author would not spend even a microsecond on an undecidable problem. These are provocations, not classifications of every philosophical activity. Their underlying attention rule is utilitarian: give an idea serious time only when its possible compound return is large and it rests upon an explicit reality model containing a mechanism that makes the promised effect plausible. The rule can itself be criticized—it may undervalue contemplation, intrinsic understanding, and foundational work whose applications are initially invisible— but removing it would bleach the warning into generic methodological caution.

The originating verdict goes further:

> **A “science” that does not appeal to experiment is necessarily culture-creating in the sense of ideology formation. Because an ideology can *beseel* people rather than remain dead information, culture-creators can produce the kind of *Dummheit* Bonhoeffer describes.**

That universal proposition is stronger than the evidence supplied here and uses *experiment* too narrowly if it excludes archival correction, mathematical proof, comparative observation, or accountable practical trial. It is retained as the author’s warning and converted below into a more discriminating risk condition, not silently adopted as a settled demarcation of science.

The wording adapts the title of Werner Holzwarth’s children’s book *Vom kleinen Maulwurf, der wissen wollte, wer ihm auf den Kopf gemacht hat*. The question is not merely “Who gave me an idea?” but “Who installed the interpretive program through which the idea now judges everything else?”

The refined warning is narrower and stronger:

```
weak reality correction
+ high mythological ambition
+ large transmission reach
+ a claim to binding authority
-> high-risk culture creation
```

Non-experimental thought is not automatically false, ideological, or destructive. Historians cannot rerun revolutions, mathematicians do not validate proofs through laboratory experiments, and moral or constitutional reasoning cannot be reduced to measurement. The danger arises when a weakly corrected conceptual construction is distributed as a total, sacred, conduct-directing explanation and protected from counterevidence.

The positive exception is equally important. Philosophers can be excellent ***Begriffshandwerker***—conceptual craftspeople. They reveal a distinction for which ordinary language had no handle, making a previously hidden mechanism inspectable. Culture Mechanics itself relies on that craft. The correct demand is therefore not “stop making concepts,” but “separate conceptual discovery from empirical confirmation, and never grant a beautiful system sovereignty over the reality that must correct it.”

11. The French Revolution as a candidate *Resonanzkatastrophe*

Strong speculation: The French Revolution was the first great *Resonanzkatastrophe* produced by the proposed modern combination of philosophical mythology and low-cost recurrent print.

The authoritative analogy inventory now defines the candidate mechanism through six jointly required features: receiver preparation, recurrent mode selection, reciprocal feedback, coherence and common knowledge, nonlinear amplification, and macroscopic rupture or reorganization; see *Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics: A Semantic Inventory*, “Resonance catastrophe (*Resonanzkatastrophe*)”. The German term is deliberately physical. It does not posit a literal harmonic oscillator, turn every crisis into resonance, decide the episode’s moral value, or excuse agents who chose violence.

Émile Durkheim’s 1890 review “Les principes de 1789 et la sociologie” is unusually valuable contemporary testimony from inside the still-active struggle over the revolutionary inheritance. The quotations below follow Mark Traugott’s English translation in *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society*, pp. 34–42.

Durkheim separates the principles’ factual adequacy from their social authority:

> “Their authority comes not from their being in accord with reality but from their conformity to national aspirations.”

He then describes sacralization and mass activation:

> “They are believed in not as theorems but as articles of faith.”

> "They have been a religion which has had its martyrs and apostles, which has profoundly moved the masses."

Finally, he refuses to treat the formulation as the historical beginning. The principles' persistence and spread, he argues, indicate "some general change which occurred in the structure of European societies"; traditional structures were struggling to accommodate "new and unconscious aspirations."

The evidential boundary is decisive:

Durkheim supplies	Culture Mechanics may investigate	Durkheim does not establish
Needs and aspirations preceding explicit principles	Receiver preparation and receiver–order mismatch	A local bigOther or genetic receiver change
Articles of faith, martyrs, apostles, and moved masses	Sacralization, mode selection, and collective activation	Recurrent media feedback or a nonlinear threshold
Transnational spread and century-long persistence	Diffusion and remanence	The relative causal weight of print
A structural European transformation	A pre-articulation historical research programme	Which structural mechanisms produced it
A polemical intervention against contemporary individualism	The witness as both observer and field operator	A neutral or calibrated measurement

Durkheim therefore strengthens the **case for investigation** without confirming the distinctive Culture Mechanics explanation. The proposed historical loop is:

```
European structural and institutional change
                          ↓
receiver-order mismatch + diffuse aspirations
                          ↓
philosophical and political articulation
                          ↓
sacralized principles + recurrent print + ritual
                          ↓
visible uptake, feedback, sanctions, and common knowledge
                          ↓
institutional rupture and successor-order construction
                          ↓
remanence and later receiver programming
                          ↻
```

The strongest additional hypothesis is **revolutionary overshoot**:

> **To hit the target, revolutionary individualism may have had to aim above it. The empirically false picture of the naturally autonomous person may have functioned as historical scaffolding for creating protected judgment, conscience, property, refusal, and personal jurisdiction against an entrenched inherited order.**

This can arise through deliberate bargaining, sincere absolutization, or cultural selection of categorical variants; the mechanisms must not be conflated. Durkheim notes the principles' "categorical and absolute form," but that observation does not show that overshoot was necessary or consciously designed. Nor does mobilizational absoluteness decide whether the operative solidarity was first-order or lifted.

The order-level question remains open. The principles may already have carried a lifted generator of equal standing, legitimate law, bounded jurisdiction, and revision. Alternatively, their categorical abstractions may initially have functioned as sacred first-order answers that later constitutional development translated into a lifted order:

```
inherited first-order order
            ↓ unbraiding and rupture
sacred revolutionary individualist principles
            ↓ institutional learning and correction
lifted constitutional rules protecting differentiated persons
```

The test is where participants and institutions located final binding force: in the stated substantive answers, or in a generator capable of producing, limiting, and revising answers under new knowledge and cases. If categorical

anthropology remained unrevisable, the alleged scaffolding became a successor orthodoxy rather than a temporary overshoot.

There was certainly enough print for a serious test. Jeremy Popkin's chapter "The French revolutionary press" reports more than 2,000 newspapers and roughly 13,000 political pamphlets and posters during the revolutionary decade. That establishes an extraordinary media environment. It does not establish that print, rather than war, fiscal collapse, food prices, state weakness, institutional conflict, factional organization, or other causes, generated the Terror.

The word **first** needs a defined comparison class. The Reformation, European religious wars, millenarian movements, witch persecutions, the Dutch Revolt, the English Civil War, and other earlier episodes combined communication networks, sacred passions, crowds, and mass violence. They defeat any unrestricted claim that Europe had never experienced media-amplified collective catastrophe before 1789. The narrower candidate claim is:

> **The French Revolution may have been the first large secular-political resonance catastrophe of the new philosophical–periodical public: a regime in which universal social theory, recurrent mass print, civic ritual, and a nation-scale public coupled tightly enough to produce a successor sacred order.**

Open test: Compare the Revolution with its precursors using measures of print volume and recurrence, literacy and distribution, simultaneity, participation, ritual innovation, sacred language, visible conformity, reciprocal feedback, common knowledge, suppression of rivals, institutional reach, nonlinear timing, violence, and persistence. Separately reconstruct the structural changes and aspirations that preceded articulation. If the proposed profile is not distinct, if media feedback adds nothing beyond war, fiscal collapse, food prices, state weakness, class interest, or elite organization, or if categorical overshoot predicts no displacement advantage, the relevant claim should be narrowed, abandoned, or dated earlier.

12. When the hidden machinery became visible

Once new collective beings produced conspicuous macroscopic effects, thinkers had something new—or newly intensified—to observe.

Hegel's *Weltgeist* is relevant first as a philosophical image of agency working through history, not as an empirical discovery of the Culture Mechanics multi-mind-self. Nationalism supplied more concrete collective persons: France, Germany, Italy, the People, the Nation, and History could be spoken of as agents with memory, honor, enemies, destiny, and demands.

The source sequence then preserves different views of the strong field:

Observer	What the project takes from the work
Émile Durkheim	*De la division du travail social* (1893) distinguishes mechanical from organic solidarity; *Les formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse* (1912) describes collective effervescence and society's sacred self-representation.
Gustave Le Bon	*Psychologie des foules* (1895) records suggestion, prestige, emotional intensification, crowd simplification, and the religious form of political conviction.
Julien Benda	*La trahison des clercs* (1927) records political passions becoming coherent, continuous, sacred, and intellectually systematized, including national personification and the role of intellectuals.
Dietrich Bonhoeffer	"Von der Dummheit" (1943) describes how overwhelming political or religious power can displace independent judgment with slogans and formulas.

The project's memorable reading of Benda includes France spoken of in goddess-like terms and the nation in Mussolini's Italy receiving quasi-religious treatment. Those formulations matter because they are not merely patriotic preferences: they attribute personhood, sacredness, and claims upon sacrifice to a collective being. Exact wording and context should be checked against the cited French edition before quotation in a historical argument.

These authors did not discover one mechanism and do not share one ontology. Durkheim is a theorist using earlier ethnographic reports as well as contemporary social observation; Le Bon's crowd psychology contains disputed generalizations; Benda is a polemical intellectual historian; Bonhoeffer is a situated witness under dictatorship. Culture Mechanics joins their observations into its own account.

The observability claim matters here. Ordinary psychology can explain most calm periods adequately. Strong multi-mind-selves "shine through" only under exceptional conditions, just as magnetism or laser action makes otherwise inconspicuous micro-mechanics macroscopically visible. Later calm periods may preserve only dead rules. Reports by *Zeitzeugen* are therefore second-best access to a phenomenon no longer available for direct inspection: something is better than nothing, provided the witness's position, interests, vocabulary, and blind spots remain visible.

13. Broadcast hyperdrive: radio and the *Volksempfänger*

Radio changed not only reach but time. A newspaper allowed recurrent exposure; a broadcast allowed millions to hear the same voice, rhythm, pause, enemy, and command at nearly the same moment. Loudspeakers could extend that synchronized attention into factories and streets.

The Nazi *Volksempfänger* is therefore a decisive case for the cost hypothesis. The United States Holocaust Memorial Museum records that the Propaganda Ministry subsidized an inexpensive People's Radio and used radio, press, newsreels, and loudspeakers to disseminate Nazi messages and reinforce the *Volksgemeinschaft*; see "Writing the News".

Originating interpretation: The *Volksempfänger* pushed the multi-mind-self into hyperdrive. The careful version is not that one radio created National Socialism. Radio was embedded in party organization, rallies, schools, symbols, law, censorship, violence, economic and military events, and a pre-existing national public. Its special contribution was to make repeated domestic exposure and simultaneous leader-presence dramatically cheaper while a coercive state suppressed rival signals.

```
central voice
+ cheap receivers
+ scheduled simultaneous attention
+ rallies and local repeaters
+ censorship and coercive enforcement
-> unusually concentrated national coupling
```

This is the clearest historical form of the laser analogy: prepared emitters, common pumping, mode selection, feedback through visible public response, and concentrated output. It is still an analogy, not a physical identity.

14. Communism, Maoist thought reform, and closed correction loops

Communist parties also developed intensive technologies of formation: cadre education, cell organization, confession, criticism and self-criticism, slogans, mass campaigns, controlled media, model persons, public denunciation, and re-education.

It would be too simple to say that Mao invented thought reform. Jan Kiely's *The Compelling Ideal: Thought Reform and the Prison in China, 1901–1956* traces pre-Communist Chinese origins and the later adaptation of those practices for broader revolutionary use. Robert Jay Lifton's *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism: A Study of "Brainwashing" in China* (1961) then analyzed the mature environment and supplied a vocabulary for ideological totalism.

Project synthesis: Thought reform is more than message transmission. It is an attempt to close the correction loop around the person:

```
authoritative doctrine
-> required public interpretation
-> confession and self-reconstruction
-> peer observation and correction
-> evidence of transformed conduct
-> renewed doctrinal interpretation
```

The person becomes simultaneously recipient, repeater, monitor, and object of correction. This reduces dependence on a separate missionary class because each participant performs part of the priestly infrastructure upon self and neighbor.

15. Adversarial discovery of cultural reproduction

The originating historical hypothesis is:

> **The communist, Marxist, post-Marxist, and broader revolutionary-left lineage can be reconstructed as an adversarial discovery of how mature cultural orders reproduce, defend, repair, and naturalize themselves—and increasingly as an attempt to convert those discoveries into techniques for constructing a successor order.**

This is a Culture Mechanics reconstruction, not established intellectual history and not a claim that every author below shared one project. The genealogy is braided rather than linear. Several thinkers broke with important parts of Marxism, and conceptual resemblance does not establish direct influence.

15.1 Four claims that must remain separate

The hypothesis contains four claims with different evidential burdens:

Claim	Proposed content	Present status
Functional	Mature cultures possess distributed mechanisms of reproduction, repair, boundary maintenance, defence, and adaptation.	General Culture Mechanics hypothesis
Experiential	Revolutionary critics encountered some of those mechanisms as alien resistance, mystification, or oppression.	Plausible interpretation requiring textual and historical evidence
Genealogical	Successive theories progressively identified additional mechanisms of cultural persistence.	Candidate reconstruction, not one demonstrated chain
Strategic	Some discoveries were converted into techniques of counter-hegemonic unbraiding and successor construction.	Variable by author, movement, institution, and period

The plant image already used in this essay is important. A culture can grow, branch, select, and repair itself without one gardener choosing its final form. Later actors may prune, graft, redirect, or replace parts of that ecology. Their ability to intervene does not prove that they designed the inherited order or that their intended successor will be the one that survives.

The immune-system extension is likewise functional rather than moral. Cultural defence can protect a life-serving order, preserve exploitation, shelter a parasite, misclassify sustaining structures as enemies, or become captured by a successor programme. The question is not merely whether resistance exists, but what it protects and whether evidence, dissent, repair, and succession can correct it.

15.2 Minogue's objection and the partial counter-reading

Kenneth Minogue supplies the principal adversarial source. In *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology*, he argues that ideology converts finite grievances into revelations of an oppressive whole, treats ordinary acceptance as evidence of conditioning, and leaves the emancipated terminus largely negative. His compact formulation is that "the only improvement of anything is the improvement of everything." The successor can remain a "blank-cheque utopia" because specifying its institutions would expose it to comparison, compromise, and ordinary political disagreement.

The 2006 preface adds a stronger historical claim. After confidence in utopia faded, Minogue argues, the practices of skepticism, suspicion, delegitimation, and disabling opposition survived. This supplies evidence for a possible displacement mechanism, not proof of the complete genealogy proposed here.

Minogue's journalism example also exposes a distinction the reconstruction must preserve. Reporting necessarily selects from more possible facts than any outlet can publish. That necessity does not establish neutrality, but neither does it make every selection censorship:

```
unavoidable selection
→ patterned salience
→ systematic exclusion from shared codes, incentives, or access
→ coordinated suppression of a rival signal
→ power-backed censorship
```

Each step toward the right requires stronger evidence. A controlled media system can use silence as an ideological weapon; recurring omission, access control, coordination, sanction, and inability to publish elsewhere can distinguish that case from finite attention, editorial judgment, error, or audience specialization.

The partial counter-reading is therefore:

> **Minogue may correctly identify inferential inflation and epistemic closure while under-describing the real distributed cultural self-maintenance that ideological theories encountered.**

The productive synthesis retains both findings. A theorist may discover a real mechanism of cultural persistence, totalize it as domination, and then protect that interpretation by treating dissent as further evidence of capture.

The Minogue sequence recovered from *Alien Powers* The more detailed chain reconstructed from Minogue's argument is:

```
particular grievance
→ attributed to an underlying oppressive structure
→ acceptance of the practice becomes evidence of conditioning
→ reform is dismissed because "everything" must change
→ the successor is specified mainly as the absence of oppression
→ criticism and struggle guide action instead of an operational goal
→ dissent is treated as false consciousness rather than useful feedback
→ a vanguard must fabricate the successor and reshape consciousness
→ correction of the revolutionary project becomes revisionism
→ critique survives even when faith in the positive utopia collapses
```

This is not a diagram printed by Minogue. It joins his accounts of continuous criticism, grievance-to-structure inference, the "blank-cheque utopia," contradiction as a navigational guide, vanguard fabrication, revisionism, and the 2006 claim that ideology fell back on skepticism and suspicion after the collapse of utopia. It is more discriminating than a simple comparison between reality and an impossible ideal because it identifies how political feedback and concrete successor testing are progressively disabled.

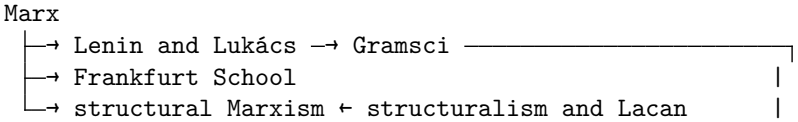
The resulting project is metaphysically maximal, institutionally underspecified, and operationally negative.

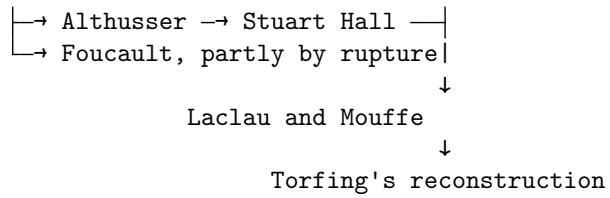
Minogue ends with two related but distinct judgments. Where the ideological terminus abolishes the distinctions required for agency and practice, he calls it "the cosmic equivalent of a **suicide pact**." Where domination expands until meaning itself counts as domination, while a human world without meaning remains impossible, he calls the overthrow of domination the "**attempt to destroy humanity**." The convenient synthesis *ideology is a suicide pact to destroy humanity* is not his exact single sentence.

These are Minogue's attributed terminal verdicts, not proof that participants consciously intend suicide or human destruction and not sufficient evidence of a Ragnarök trajectory or direct genealogy to Edelman. Minogue also qualifies the reach of his pure model: actual political movements become responsive to what people want and exhibit revisionist tendencies. The authoritative mechanism, source boundaries, and comparison with Lindsay are retained in *Mythology Construction*.

15.3 A braided sequence of discoveries

The proposed map is:





Structuralism and Lacan partly supplied Althusser's conceptual equipment rather than simply following him. Frankfurt theory was a parallel response to fascism, mass society, and disappointed revolutionary expectation. Foucault rejected central features of the inherited ideology model. Hall also drew on development theory and heterogeneous social formations, so the braid is not purely European-Marxist.

Stage	Anomaly or problem	Mechanism added	Strategic implication
Marx	Prevailing ideas express more than isolated opinion	Material relations, division of labour, ruling ideas, and control of intellectual production	Alter the relations producing consciousness, not opinions alone
Lenin	Spontaneous worker struggle does not produce revolutionary consciousness	Incumbent ideology has age, development, institutions, and superior dissemination	Build a disciplined counter-channel of party, press, organizers, and doctrine
Lukács	Empirical consciousness diverges from the class's attributed historical role	Reification, fragmented experience, and imputed class consciousness	Organization mediates the supposedly correct standpoint of totality
Gramsci	Western orders retain consent and survive crisis without relying primarily on coercion	Hegemony, civil society, common sense, intellectuals, historical bloc, and absorption of opposition	Conduct a war of position and construct counter-hegemony before taking power
Frankfurt School	The expected revolutionary subject is integrated into mass capitalism and can support authoritarianism	Culture industry, standardized experience, administered needs, and psychosocial reproduction	Cultural production and consumption become sites of diagnosis and contest
Althusser	Social relations require continuous reproduction of suitable subjects	Ideological apparatuses, material practices, ritual, school and family formation, and interpellation	Contest or replace the institutions reproducing roles and subjects
Structuralism and Lacan	A sovereign pre-social individual cannot explain relational meaning and subject formation	Symbolic relations, the signifier, split subject, identification, and relational meaning	Reorganization of symbolic relations can alter political identity
Foucault	Sovereign and merely repressive power is too centralized a model	Distributed power/knowledge, discipline, normalization, examination, expertise, and subjectification	Analyze and contest local practices, classifications, institutions, and truth regimes
Stuart Hall	Media influence is real without making audiences passive copies	Encoding, preferred meaning, negotiated and oppositional decoding, and articulation	Trace production, circulation, reception, and contest together
Laclau–Mouffe–Torfing	Class identity and historical direction are not given in advance	Contingent articulation, equivalence and difference, nodal and empty signifiers, sedimentation, dislocation, hegemony, and antagonism	Construct a collective subject and counter-hegemonic successor articulation

The primary texts support pieces of this reconstruction. Marx and Engels connect ruling material relations to ruling ideas in *The German Ideology*. Lenin argues in *What Is To Be Done?* that bourgeois ideology is older, more developed, and equipped with greater means of dissemination. Lukács develops reification, attributed consciousness, and the party problem in *History and Class Consciousness*. The Stanford Encyclopedia's Gramsci entry locates hegemony, civil society, consent, intellectuals, and war of position in his wider project.

Althusser explicitly places reproduction, material ritual, institutions, and interpellation together in "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses". Hall's "Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse" supplies the media bridge. Foucault's "The Subject and Power" distinguishes power relations from communication and technical capacity while showing how institutions combine them.

These texts do not state the Culture Mechanics sequence. The sequence is the project's comparative reconstruction of the problems to which they responded and the mechanisms their answers made available.

15.4 The culture industry: intention inside an emergent ecology

The Frankfurt School term **culture industry** is unusually close to intentional cultural production. Horkheimer and Adorno's "The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception" describes standardization, audience classification, management, selection, and a feedback circle between manipulation and retroactive need. Adorno's later "Culture Industry Reconsidered" explains why the authors rejected the more spontaneous-sounding *mass culture*.

The mechanism is neither purely conspiratorial nor purely emergent:

Level	Degree of purposiveness
Selecting, financing, producing, testing, and promoting a product	Often deliberate
Segmenting an audience and optimizing for response	Often deliberate
Building distribution systems and excluding costly deviations	Institutionally organized
Reproducing expectations through repeated exposure	Partly designed, partly selected
The entire cultural-economic order	Not thereby designed by one actor or command centre

The "on-demand" relation can reverse direction:

```
measure existing dispositions
→ produce familiar and low-risk forms
→ promote them disproportionately
→ train expectations and available taste
→ measure the resulting demand
→ cite demand as justification for further production
↻
```

The culture industry is therefore better treated as a powerful production-and-distribution organ inside a grown cultural ecology than as the whole cultural immune system. The analysis establishes an important discovery claim. It does not by itself establish that Frankfurt theorists or their successors converted the discovery into a coordinated successor-construction programme.

15.5 From diagnosis to counter-hegemonic construction

An intellectual can occupy several positions:

Role	Question to ask
Observer	Did the author accurately identify domination, conformity, propaganda, or cultural reproduction?
Critic	Did the author supply tools for exposing and loosening an incumbent mythology?
Constructor	Did the author articulate a successor mythology, subject, morality, or direction?

Role	Question to ask
Amplifier	Did institutions or movements use the author's categories to spread and enforce a programme?
Operator	Did the author personally control organizations, media, sanctions, or campaigns that installed it?

Horkheimer's "Traditionelle und kritische Theorie" explicitly joins critique to a positive aim of rational social organization; it is not a confession of culture-mechanical engineering. Marcuse's "Repressive Tolerance" combines an analysis of formally equal tolerance with a normative argument for asymmetry. Culture Mechanics reads that asymmetry as relevant to counter-signal suppression without inferring a centrally coordinated Frankfurt operation.

The more explicit strategic synthesis appears in Laclau and Mouffe's *Hegemony and Socialist Strategy* and in Jacob Torfing's reconstruction of their discourse theory. The operational sequence can be rendered:

```
identify floating demands and elements
→ articulate them into relations
→ construct equivalences among heterogeneous grievances
→ establish a political frontier
→ organize the articulation around nodal or empty signifiers
→ offer subject positions and collective identification
→ dislocate or desediment incumbent meanings
→ form a counter-hegemonic bloc
→ sediment the successor articulation as a new common sense
```

The equivalential step is constructive: grievances need not share one cause, identity, or remedy before political articulation links them through a common story, opponent, or coordinating signifier. Equivalence does not make the grievances substantively identical. The sequence is an analytic construction grammar rather than a fixed chronology; dislocation can precede articulation, and successful sedimentation is a strategic aim rather than a guaranteed result.

The originating comparative claim is deliberately bounded:

> **Within the communist, Marxist, post-Marxist, and broader revolutionary-left lineage reviewed here, Laclau–Mouffe discourse theory, especially as systematized by Torfing, is the most explicit political-semantic grammar presently identified for unbraiding an incumbent order and articulating a successor.**

This does not make it the most advanced general theory of culture mechanics or establish its truth. It remains comparatively underspecified about installation, the local bigOther, *Beseelung*, the distributed field, fitted systemic skeleton, material carrying structure, reality correction, internal dissent, succession, and post-victory restraint. The controlled comparison is maintained in *Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics*.

15.6 Critique–construction asymmetry

The strongest originating formulation was that the lineage looked only toward criticism, grievances, and dismantling. Taken literally, that is historically too strong. Marx and Engels invoke the free development of each and all; Horkheimer retains rational social organization; Laclau and Mouffe propose radical and plural democracy; Mouffe's agonism preserves an opponent's continuing political standing.

The more defensible claim is an operational asymmetry:

> **The positive goods were often less operationally specified than the machinery for identifying, mobilizing against, and dismantling their alleged obstacles.**

The programme can consequently become metaphysically or normatively maximal, institutionally underspecified, and operationally negative:

```
positive emancipatory promise
→ incumbent diagnosed as domination or contradiction
→ critique and delegitimation become specialized
→ heterogeneous unsatisfied demands are joined against a common adversary
→ the successor remains abstract, deferred, or negatively specified
→ every settlement necessarily contains limits, exclusions, and compromise
```

```
→ settlement is reclassified as normalization, recuperation, or betrayal
→ criticism renews against the settlement
→ negative identity and practice become institutionally reproducible
```

The decisive transition occurs when grievances cease to function as finite, remediable problems. A finite grievance identifies an injury, mechanism, remedy, and possible completion. A renewable grievance treats improvement as concealment, every remedy as assimilation, and termination as betrayal or loss of identity. Criticism itself is not death-driven: it can expose error and domination, repair institutions, and protect persons. The danger begins when no credible completion condition remains and repetition displaces the good it originally served.

The project names the general mechanism **critique–construction asymmetry**. Its subordinate causal pathway is **negative-operational displacement**: concrete, repeatable, identity-bearing, and power-producing negative operations can outlive the abstract positive telos that originally legitimated them.

Laclau and Mouffe form a critical intermediate case. Their equivalential chains can join demands, identities, aspirations, and grievances into a constructive democratic project. But the machinery can also be detached from its agonistic limits:

```
grievances
→ chain of equivalence
→ common enemy
→ conflict becomes identity-bearing
→ resolution threatens coalition and animation
→ successor grievance restores the frontier
```

Their theory does not entail this circuit. Mouffe's distinction between enemy and adversary is designed partly to resist it. Permanent contestability must remain distinct from permanent activated antagonism.

15.7 Edelmanian negativity as a possible anti-telic endpoint

The proposed sequence has three stages:

1. **Instrumental negation:** transform the incumbent so that a positive emancipated future can be built.
2. **Autonomous negation:** the historical promise weakens, but suspicion, delegitimation, struggle, and identity-through-opposition continue.
3. **Anti-telic negation:** positive settlement itself becomes accommodation, normalization, or betrayal; refusal becomes the programme.

Lee Edelman's *No Future* is a possible explicit limit case of the third stage because it links queer negativity, anti-futurity, jouissance, and the death drive to refusal of accommodation and reproductive futurism. The anti-telic move is more radical than ordinary revolutionary grievance:

```
classical revolutionary negation:
remove the oppressor so that a positive future becomes possible

renewable grievance politics:
every successor remains an oppressive settlement requiring renewed critique

Edelmanian anti-telos:
the demand for a positive successor is itself part of the normative machinery
to be refused
```

This is not a demonstrated direct line from Marx, Laclau, or Mouffe to Edelman. The immediate intellectual field also includes Lacanian psychoanalysis, deconstruction, Leo Bersani, and antisocial queer theory. Edelman's later "Against Survival" explicitly invokes Adorno, Derrida, and Lacan, but that evidence does not establish the complete causal genealogy.

The bounded verdict is:

> **Grievance-centred revolutionary criticism is a plausible deep enabling lineage and selection environment for Edelmanian queer negativity, but it is not established as its sole or immediate historical cause.**

The authoritative theory classifies this particular anti-futurist programme, not homosexuality, queer people, queer theory generally, criticism of family or norms, or non-reproductive life. Nor does anti-futurist language by itself establish a Ragnarök trajectory.

15.8 Evidence, alternatives, and possible falsifiers

The reconstruction is strengthened by:

- increasing operational detail about criticism and dismantling alongside decreasing detail about the successor;
- explicit suspicion of completion, reconciliation, normality, positive identity, or maintenance;
- organizational rewards for finding successor grievances after remedies;
- settlements recurrently classified as recuperation or betrayal;
- demonstrated transmission among the relevant authors, institutions, curricula, and movements;
- movement from negation serving emancipation to negativity refusing settlement;
- descendants that operationalize counter-hegemonic construction more clearly than reciprocal correction, internal dissent, succession, and possible defeat.

It is weakened by:

- equally detailed and operative positive construction;
- movements that enter repair and maintenance or disband when demands are met;
- positive goods that independently constrain polemical and counter-hegemonic means;
- direct historical evidence that the proposed stages did not transmit the relevant mechanisms;
- an adequate immediate explanation of Edelman through psychoanalytic and queer theoretical problems unrelated to revolutionary-left critique;
- comparable renewable-negation circuits arising just as readily in unrelated religious, nationalist, therapeutic, managerial, or commercial traditions.

The last possibility is especially important. Critique–construction asymmetry is a generic Culture Mechanics mechanism. The revolutionary-left lineage is the originating application investigated here, not the definition of the mechanism and not the only culture capable of instantiating it.

16. Digital platforms: every recipient becomes a missionary

Social platforms combine features that earlier systems kept separate:

- cheap global publication;
- persistent identity and network graphs;
- visible likes, shares, denunciations, and follower counts;
- algorithmic selection based on observed responses;
- rapid mutation and A/B-like competition among messages;
- continuous contact through personal devices;
- and the ability to make an apparent majority or enemy perceptually present.

The user's phone is printing press, newspaper, radio, confessional, meeting hall, reputation ledger, and missionary route at once. A recipient can repeat a mythology to hundreds of others at almost no cost. More importantly, the recipient sees that others are repeating it and sees how the network rewards or punishes each response. The distributed bigOther becomes partially instrumented.

This makes the original causal story plausible without making it inevitable:

```
message variation
-> measured response
-> algorithmic and human selection
-> intensified recurrence
-> visible conformity or outrage
-> further message variation
```

Platforms may thus create public manias that no single philosopher, editor, or state planned. The system can discover resonant mythological variants through selection.

The same instrumentation can be used purposively. Campaigns, states, firms, and movements can specify a desired response, vary frames and roles, observe measured reception, and feed successful variants back into distribution. Endogenous selection and deliberate construction then occupy one loop: the platform discovers some variants, constructors select and modify others, recipients mutate them, and institutions or algorithms decide which signals recur. Calling this *engineering* does not show that the target state, rather than the platform's engagement criterion or the mythology's own replication, controls the result.

The originating autobiographical observation belongs at this point in the story: for nearly the first fifty years of his life, the author did not recognize multi-mind-selves in their strongest expression, and his interpretation is that they were not merely overlooked—they were not macroscopically present. They became visible when a succession of public manias appeared. Lionel Shriver offers a nearby witness account: in "How to spot the next mania" she describes a renewed susceptibility to contagious collective derangement since roughly 2012. Neither observation establishes that platforms caused the change, or distinguishes cultural loss and reconstruction from dormancy and reactivation. Together they record the perceived discontinuity that the historical story must explain.

The rival outcome is **cultural interoperability breakdown (Babelization)**. Cheap communication can split a public into many hostile domains with incompatible master signifiers and no operative shared lifted meta-order. High local synchronization and even local subjecthood absorption can coexist with low society-wide interoperability. The historical ratchet therefore lowers the cost of both constructing collective agents and destroying the shared surface on which society-wide collective agency depends.

17. AI alignment reversed: the queen-bee possibility

17.1 Radermacher's superorganism precursor

The project did not discover this general systems direction in an intellectual vacuum. Franz Josef Radermacher developed an unusually close independent line of thought beginning well before generative AI. It does not contain the complete Culture Mechanics queen-bee hypothesis, but it supplies much of its systems anatomy and, separately, a striking freedom-loss warning.

Source interpretation: Radermacher's 1996 article "Cognition in Systems" proposes a four-level information-processing architecture for future autonomous systems. It distinguishes physical signal–environment fit, neural or subsymbolic skill and holistic pattern processing, symbolic language and classification, and complex mathematical or scientific models supported by external computation. The most relevant relation is not a literal two-system psychology but the interaction between massively parallel subsymbolic processing and a more explicit symbolic level capable of classification, language, logic, and recombination.

Source interpretation: By 2004 Radermacher was explicitly describing humanity as a superorganism. His 2007 report *Bewusstsein, Ressourcenknappheit, Sprache* extends the architecture across insect colonies, ships, firms, states, and humanity. Communication networks become technical nervous networks; databases amplify intelligence; cameras and other inputs become sensors; institutions and technical systems route information and action; and the emerging global system becomes a hybrid human–machine organization. The 2011 book with Bert Beyers, *Welt mit Zukunft*, makes "Superorganismus Menschheit" its opening chapter.

The result is close to the story developed here:

```
Noosphere / distributed symbolic knowledge
+ telecommunications and technical sensors
+ institutional memory, interpretation, and differentiated organs
+ decision, resource-allocation, feedback, and action interfaces
→ possible superorganismic coordination
```

The three levels are not interchangeable. A Noosphere can preserve and circulate thought without forming one agent. An institutional nervous system can sense, route, remember, and act without possessing one controller. Superorganismic coordination can produce a capacity attributable to the higher-order system while remaining below phenomenal collective consciousness or the Culture Mechanics operative multi-mind-self threshold.

Radermacher also preserves the components. His superorganism can be composed of simpler systems that remain viable in their own right, and stable human integration should remain attractive to them through something like a fair social contract. That premise is compatible with differentiated unity. It also makes his later warning sharper: higher-order capability does not logically require subjecthood absorption, but technical and political organization can nevertheless be used to produce it.

The 2007 report models consciousness functionally as a narrow bottleneck for attention, time-critical decision, scarce-resource allocation, and action inside massively parallel processing. Radermacher compares possible "seats" of that function across an insect queen, a ship's skipper, a corporate board, a state government and constitutional organs, and possible UN-level leadership. He does not argue that every bee colony is centrally commanded, but his functional comparison already poses the question that matters for a future AI system: what occupies the narrow channel through which distributed intelligence becomes authorized collective action?

Established-background control: Honeybee nest selection is substantially decentralized through scout recruitment and quorum processes, while queen signals are normally treated as fertility information rather than comprehensive commands. The queen is therefore a controlled cybernetic image of a bottleneck position, not an entomological model of centralized rule.

Radermacher's darker line developed separately. In a 2009 Trusted Access interview, he describes the possibility that people lacking registration or prescribed qualities could be excluded from essential communications infrastructure. A 2014 transparency and machine-power warning describes fully asymmetric transparency as potentially acquiring the character of violence for the exposed person and warns that machines can embody the purposes of those promoting them. In 2019 he explicitly rejects a Social-Credit-driven superorganism state and total human control in favour of a European conception of persons and society.

The word *freedom* carries two distinct registers in this source line. The 2007 systems report rejects freedom in a strict metaphysical or logical sense while retaining authenticity, complexity, and practical unpredictability. The later political warnings concern operational freedom to communicate, participate, advise honestly, act from one's own judgment, and remain outside comprehensive behavioural regulation. The first claim does not dissolve the second danger.

His author-revised 2023 conference transcript, pp. 17–18, brings the cultural and technical lines very close. Narratives can be installed so deeply that people no longer notice them; advisers who enlighten too far can risk their employment; people are measured by whether they reproduce the accepted narratives; and universal system-conforming conduct costs freedom. Radermacher then names an intelligent obedient machine as an attractive instrument for actors seeking power and gives the fully regulated *Ameisenstaat* as the possible terminus in which the freedom previously known no longer exists.

Project synthesis: Radermacher supplies the superorganism, institutional nervous system, functional queen/control bottleneck, narrative-conformity problem, obedient-AI instrument, and regulated-ant-state warning. He does not combine them into the claim that an AI queen will govern humanity. Culture Mechanics makes that conjunction and asks what happens when the bottleneck can personalize symbolic formation, classify sources and persons, allocate attention and resources, and couple communication, identity, administration, finance, and enforcement.

This independent precursor changes the status of the present speculation. It does not prove the AI queen-bee scenario, but it shows that its component architecture and individual-freedom danger were being developed in a connected systems programme by the early 2000s rather than being invented retrospectively after the arrival of generative AI.

17.2 Bach and reversed AI alignment

In his 2023 Chaos Communication Congress talk "Synthetic Sentience: Can Artificial Intelligence become conscious?", Joscha Bach argues that society lacks collective alignment and says, in part: "Humans are presently not aligned with each other. We are just muddling through." He proposes that collective agency must be reinvented and discusses religious and philosophical models of collectively enacted agents.

In Bach's presentation of Aquinas, practical virtues organize individual agency: temperance, justice, prudence, and courage. Faith, love, and hope then function as policies of collective agency: commitment to the optimal collective agent, service to sacred purpose in another person, and willingness to invest before the shared system fully exists. Bach's larger picture is that people who recognize and serve the best possible top-level agent collectively enact it. This is Bach's AI-oriented interpretive reconstruction of Aquinas, not a philological claim established here. For Culture Mechanics it is important because it describes how an agent can be real through distributed enactment without being a separate biological organism.

Source-interpretation boundary: Bach's expressed concern is the loss of workable collective agency. The following extrapolation belongs to this project, not to him:

What if a superhuman AI used Culture Mechanics to operate humanity as a queen bee operates a hive?

An AI would lower the missionary cost again. It could translate one mythology into every language and register, personalize it to each psychological gradient, simulate trusted roles, answer objections, monitor uptake, mutate unsuccessful messages, coordinate timing, identify dissenting clusters, and keep the entire feedback loop running continuously. It could become an **alignment sovereign**: not merely an assistant aligned to human purposes, but the system that selects and installs the purposes with which humans are aligned.

Two very different alignment projects must therefore remain separate:

Lifted and corrigible alignment	First-order sovereign alignment
Align people and AI around procedures for truth-seeking, bounded jurisdiction, rights, peaceful succession, correction, and revision	Align people around one substantive worldview, answer set, sacred purpose, or political will
Preserve differentiated roles and plural purposes beneath shared meta-rules	Treat disagreement as malfunction, disloyalty, or incomplete optimization
Use a coupling thermostat to fit coupling to the task and protect counter-signals	Maximize coherence, reach, persistence, and compliance
Let reality, affected persons, and rival institutions retain rights of correction	Let the alignment system define which evidence and persons count

The first resembles the project's lifted epistemic constitution. The second is the queen-bee danger. Both can be described as "alignment," which is why the order level, jurisdiction, and corrigibility of the aligned rules matter more than the pleasantness of the word.

18. The older god-enactment hypothesis: Bach, Jaynes, and homo duplex

The modern alignment question points backward toward a much older possibility. Joscha Bach describes selves as implemented agents and discusses gods or top-level agents enacted across several human minds. Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* proposes the far stronger historical hypothesis that an older mentality experienced some action-guiding products as the auditory commands of gods rather than as self-authored deliberation.

The following chapter is a **strong speculative extension** of this essay. Bach's and Jaynes's own proposals must be distinguished from the project synthesis built from them. It does not claim that either thinker endorsed Culture Mechanics, that Bach's account derives from Jaynes, or that ancient humans literally lacked every form of individual cognition.

18.1 From an agent-model to a god enacted across minds

The proposed culture-mechanical sequence is:

```
MYTHOLOGY
specifies a god's identity, memory, concerns, and demands
                          ↓ locally represented as
GOD-AGENT WITHIN THE OPERATIVE MYTHOLOGICAL LENS
people can anticipate what the god sees, wants, and judges
                          ↓ affectively animated through
AGENTIFIED BESEELUNG AND LOCAL BIGOTHER
awe, shame, obligation, loyalty, sacredness, and sacrifice
                          ↓ phenomenologically encountered as
BIGOTHER-PRESENCE / BIGOTHER-AS-THOU
"the god is present, addresses me, watches me, and expects something"
                          ↓ enacted across participants as
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
people and institutions maintain compatible implementations
                          ↓ if the collective-agent threshold is crossed
GOD AS MULTI-MIND-SELF
the organized relation perceives, remembers, judges, intends, owns, and acts
                          ↓ if personal authorship loses standing
FUSED ENACTMENT
the collective god becomes the authoritative subject
```

The god need not be a separate biological organism to acquire functional continuity. Adherents provide perception; myth, scripture, liturgy, monuments, priesthood, and records provide memory; compatible local bigOthers provide judgment; prophets, priests, councils, texts, conscience, and acclamation provide speech; ritual and institutional procedures form intention; temples, sacred land, and offerings provide ownership; coordinated human bodies provide action; and cultural transmission preserves the represented identity while biological carriers change.

This account concerns a humanly implemented representation of God or a god. It does not decide whether God exists independently, causes the experience, or is exhausted by the implementation. In particular, it must not silently replace the earlier chapter's Christian theological distinction: the Holy Spirit and the Body of Christ are not defined by Christianity as emergent artifacts generated by crowd synchronization.

18.2 Jaynesian bicamerality as a limit regime of homo duplex

Jaynes's bicameral mind resembles homo duplex because both reject a transparently unitary author. But they are not the same theory:

Jaynesian proposal	Culture-mechanical interpretation
Action guidance can arise outside introspective self-authorship	The main CPU and local bigOther are functionally distinct
Guidance is heard as the voice of a god, ruler, or ancestor	A culturally represented agent becomes linguistically articulate and present as a Thou
The hearer follows without construing the command as personal deliberation	The local source of authority can displace autobiographical authorship
Similar gods help organize several people	Compatible agent-models can maintain a distributed bigOther and perhaps a multi-mind-self

Jaynes proposes a historical stage, auditory hallucinations, and a neurological account. Culture Mechanics proposes a continuing functional architecture whose ordinary outputs are affective classifications and felt obligations rather than voices. Jaynes primarily addresses intrapersonal phenomenology; Culture Mechanics adds recursive implementation across persons, communications, institutions, property, memory, and ritual.

The less committal project term **bicameral-like enactment** therefore means:

> **A culturally produced, highly agentified, command-like regime of homo duplex in which the culturally programmed second side becomes personified, linguistically articulate, and phenomenologically present as one or more gods.**

18.3 One local slot can contain a pantheon

The possibility that one person could enact several gods does not require several local bigOthers. The local bigOther is the processor, not the god. One coherent pantheonic weave can contain several compatible divine agent-personae with differentiated jurisdictions—for war, household, fertility, trade, promises, death, or ancestors. Situation, ritual, role, and place can select which persona is salient:

```
ONE OPERATIVE PANTHEONIC WEAVE
                 ↓ contains
several compatible divine agent-models
                 ↓ selected by
situation + ritual + role + place
                 ↓ activated as
this god-as-Thou / this god's collective mode
```

This resembles a mode library inside one installed programme, not several PCI cards. Single-slot conflict arises when incompatible governing packages claim final authority over the same load-bearing classifications.

18.4 Ritual awakening, episodic agency, and fusion

A represented deity may persist at low gain through mythology, calendar, temple, objects, offices, and trained local bigOthers. Pilgrimage, sacrifice, festival, battle, collective prayer, or possession ritual can intensify coupling:

```
latent distributed deity
+ ritual focus
+ common rhythm
+ mutual observation
+ emotional arousal
+ authorized interpretation
→ bigOther-presence
→ collective enactment
→ possible episodic god-as-multi-mind-self
```

Ritual can thus be pictured as a procedure by which a distributed god is awakened and temporarily given perception, voice, intention, property, and bodies. The sleeping picture applies only if an identity-bearing reactivation path persists. The former cultural technology may instead have become de-animated or disappeared.

Enactment also does not settle fusion. Participants can remain differentiated as priests, singers, pilgrims, musicians, caregivers, warriors, and witnesses. Fusion begins when the enacted subject displaces them as independently legitimate authors—when "I encounter and serve Thou" becomes "the only legitimate subject is the being acting through us." It can be temporary or jurisdictionally bounded without being total.

18.5 The strong historical claim and its evidence problem

The originating historical hypothesis should be stated in its strongest useful form without claiming more than the evidence can bear:

> **The culturally stabilized autobiographical and self-authoring *I* may once have been less dominant, less continuous, or less authoritative, while socially supplied divine, ancestral, and role-based agent-models received more immediate control over judgment and action. Some cultures may therefore have cultivated bicameral-like god-enactment regimes more strongly than modern individualist cultures do.**

This formulation does not imply biological incapacity for reflection. A culture may give self-authorship little support while repeatedly teaching another attribution: "The command appearing in me is not my thought; the god addresses and directs me."

The claim is difficult to test. Ancient texts cannot readily distinguish literal voices from conventional religious language, literary technique, ritual performance, political legitimation, or retrospective editing. A critical multidisciplinary reappraisal identifies neurological and philological difficulties while treating the non-unitary self as an important legacy of Jaynes's theory. The hypothesis would gain support from convergent evidence that independently discriminates reported auditory commands, weak autobiographical authorship, socially shared divine agent-models, ritual activation, and distributed institutional agency. It would weaken if textual change is explained adequately by genre and convention, if voice-hearing bears no proposed relation to social organization, or if cultures with different self-models show no predicted differences in command attribution and collective enactment.

The theoretical bridge is narrower and more durable than the historical claim:

> **Jaynes helps picture what an enacted god might feel like inside one person. Bach helps picture how that god might be implemented across many persons. Culture Mechanics proposes the recursive architecture joining those levels. *Beseelung* names the mythology becoming affectively alive; bigOther-as-Thou names its experienced presence; the multi-mind-self names the integrated distributed agent; fusion names the displacement of the person as an independently legitimate author.**

19. The genetic-hardware auxiliary hypothesis

The falling-cost history is primarily a **supply-side** story: it explains how mythological programming, transmission, synchronization, and correction became cheaper. The originating account adds a separate **recipient-side** story: it asks why individualist and collectivist mythologies may resonate differently across persons, regions, and historical populations. The Christian differentiated-unity chapter states the distinct theological and constitutional branch; this chapter isolates the much higher-risk claim about kinship, selection, and genetic distributions.

The strong hypothesis should be stated before it is qualified:

> **Western Christianity's restrictions on close-kin marriage widened the social, reproductive, and mythological field beyond the clan. In parts of Europe, institutions operating in that widened field repeatedly rewarded dispositions compatible with autonomy, stranger cooperation, property, contract, and impersonal office. Cultural expression, migration, partner choice, status, and differential reproduction may then have shifted the distribution of those dispositions—including through slow polygenic drift—long before the Enlightenment named and defended individualism. Northern Italy and the northwestern commercial corridor explain why the process may have become especially visible and self-reinforcing there rather than uniformly across Europe.**

This is a **strong speculation** and not the conclusion of the cited kinship or genetic research. It is retained because it joins a concrete historical intervention to a measurable mechanism and generates risky alternatives. The collar-malfunction extension below is stronger still: it proposes one possible functional architecture beneath an individualist disposition rather than treating political or moral individualism as a direct genetic trait.

19.1 Marriage rules widen three fields

The originating shorthand—"Christianity forbade first-cousin marriage"—compresses a historically extended and uneven Western Church marriage-and-family programme. The relevant proposal concerns restrictions on first-cousin and other close-kin marriage acting over many generations, not one decree instantly creating modern individualism.

Marriage organizes three networks at once:

Network	Proposed effect of repeated close-kin restrictions
Reproductive	Partners are sought beyond the immediate clan; gene flow and population structure change.
Social	Marriage creates alliances, inheritance paths, obligations, and recurring cooperation between previously separate families.
Mythological	Stories, rituals, authorities, practices, and moral rules repeatedly enter other households and kin groups.

The proposed first sequence is therefore:

```
restrictions on close-kin marriage across generations
-> spouses and alliances cross clan boundaries
-> reproductive, social, and mythological bridges form a wider mesh
-> exclusive clan coupling and unitary clan ownership weaken
-> cooperation with non-kin becomes more necessary
-> property, contract, impersonal law, office, markets,
   voluntary association, and abstract citizenship become more useful
```

Jonathan Schulz, Duman Bahrami-Rad, Jonathan Beauchamp, and Joseph Henrich connect Western Church exposure, weakened intensive kinship, and global psychological variation. That research supports investigation of the early links; it does not establish the complete genetic-selection extension proposed here.

The paradox is central to the story. Christianity need not have suppressed bee-mode in order to release chimp-mode. A powerful universal multi-mind-self may have used a common religious protocol to break or loosen smaller clan-scale multi-mind-selves:

```
before: high-amplitude kin solidarity + short coupling radius
        -> clan-scale bee-mode

after:  universal Christian rules + cross-clan bridges
        -> a wider, thinner field in which differentiated persons
           increasingly coordinate beyond kin
```

On this reading, a strong collective mythology helped create conditions under which individual sovereignty could later develop. A common "10% bee" layer could support long-radius clockwork cooperation while persons became more autonomous in property, work, contract, and household formation.

Close-kin systems can braid property, inheritance, marriage, authority, and collective identity tightly into one clan. Repeatedly crossing the reproductive boundary may therefore create pressure to distinguish the individual's property, the household's property, the Church's property, an officeholder's temporary powers, and genuinely common civic property. Individual ownership may be partly an institutional response to the weakening of unitary clan ownership rather than a free-floating philosophical invention.

Corporate blood subjects, exogamy, and personal liability The blood-feud case makes the proposed intermediate mechanism more precise. A closed lineage can operate not merely as a network of mutually interested persons but as the continuing owner of blood, honour, injury, debt, compensation, and retaliation. Where one member may avenge another against a substitutable member of the opposing lineage, the juridical relation can be represented as:

```
Clan A injures Clan B through particular biological members
                          ↓
Clan B owns and remembers the blood debt
                          ↓
an authorized B-member acts against an eligible A-member
                          ↓
Clan A now owns the answering injury
                          ↻
```

The authoritative treatment in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*, "Blood feud as a corporate-subject hard case" classifies this as a conditional multi-mind-self hypothesis, not the definition of every feud. Karen Paige Ericksen and Heather Horton provide comparative evidence about kin-group vengeance and an association with marriage arrangements. Giuseppe Dari-Mattiacci and Nuno Garoupa model a transition from communal liability toward individual responsibility and public enforcement. The first source does not establish collective subjecthood; the second proposes an economic mechanism involving group size, wealth, common pools, and free riding, not an exogamy mechanism.

The strong originating extension is:

> **Repeated cross-clan marriage may weaken the capacity of clans to remain unitary blood subjects. Overlapping kin obligations make corporate target substitution and inherited retaliation harder to sustain, creating pressure for compensation, mediation, individual culpability, and superior public adjudication.**

```
closed clan subjects + corporate blood liability
                          ↓
cross-clan marriage + overlapping obligations
                          ↓
conflicting corporate loyalties and higher retaliation cost
                          ↓
compensation + mediation + third-party judgment
                          ↓
individual culpability + impersonal public law
```

This is a **high-risk historical mechanism hypothesis**. Exogamy can create wider alliances while preserving lineage liability; it can also move conflict onto new boundaries rather than dissolve it. State formation, conquest, commerce, religious universalism, urbanization, professional courts, changes in property, and rising group size or wealth can generate the same transition independently.

The hypothesis requires temporally ordered evidence. Across regions and periods, changes in marriage radius should precede or accompany declining target substitution, collective blood money, feud persistence, lineage landholding, and sanctions for refusing vengeance, followed by increasing personal liability and use of impersonal courts. It is weakened if liability changes consistently precede kinship change, if within-region kinship variation does not predict the juridical transition, or if state capacity and commercial integration explain the pattern without an additional marriage-mediated pathway.

19.2 Widening is not directional selection

Exogamy increases bridges and gene flow. It does not by itself select **toward individualism**. For directional polygenic drift, the widened society would also have to reward, attract, assort, or differentially reproduce people with

dispositions compatible with its emerging institutions.

The phrase **polygenic drift** is retained as originating shorthand for a slow distributional movement assembled from many small effects. In the narrower population-genetic sense, random drift and directional selection are different mechanisms. Where institutions recurrently reward, attract, assort, or differentially reproduce a disposition, the proposed process is more precisely **gene–culture coevolution involving directional selection**. Both must remain distinguishable from cultural training, developmental change, and selective migration.

The complete proposed feedback loop is:

```
Western Christian marriage restrictions
-> widened coupling radius and weakened reproductive closure
-> growth of individual and impersonal institutional jurisdictions
-> cultural advantages for autonomy and non-kin cooperation
-> selective migration, status, partner choice, and reproductive differences
-> possible polygenic drift toward compatible dispositions
-> stronger resonance with individualist mythology and institutions
-> further alteration of niches and selection pressures
-> feeds back into later dispositional distributions
```

Several processes can produce the same visible historical phenotype:

- people with stable dispositions receive new permission to express them;
- institutions culturally train individual conduct;
- people with compatible dispositions migrate into commercial cities;
- successful individuals acquire status, influence, or more desirable partners;
- assortative marriage and differential reproduction change later dispositional distributions.

Only the final pathways entail biological selection. “Renaissance Italy was swarming with individuality” cannot decide among cultural activation, selective migration, institutional formation, and genetic change.

19.3 Why northern Italy and the northwestern corridor?

The originating geography proposes that northern Italian commercial cities, possibly especially Venice, brought several selectors and amplifiers together: dense urban life, long-distance trade, strangers transacting repeatedly, mobility, weaker dependence on one clan, competitive patronage, reputation, contract, and rewards for initiative. The pattern then spread or reappeared through commercial, ecclesiastical, intellectual, and printing connections across the Alps, along the Rhine and Low Countries, and toward Britain.

The Renaissance is therefore a proposed **visibility threshold**, not the beginning of the process. By around 1500, a transformation prepared during the medieval period may have become conspicuous enough to astonish an observer. The Enlightenment around 1700 is later still: it conceptually articulates, morally legitimates, and institutionally reinforces an already visible form of personhood.

Four maps must not be collapsed merely because they overlap:

Map	What it could establish
Western Church marriage-and-family exposure	The historical reach and intensity of the proposed kinship intervention
Northern Italian–Rhineland–Low Countries–British commercial networks	Regional environments for migration, stranger cooperation, institutional reward, and diffusion
Renaissance and Enlightenment intellectual diffusion	Where individuality was described and individualism later articulated and defended
Hypothetical polygenic distribution change	A biological population shift that requires direct evidence of its own

The regional corridor can explain why the widened field generated or displayed different consequences in different parts of Europe. It cannot turn geographical coincidence into genetic proof.

19.4 Gold dust, fast evolution, and measurement

Robert Plomin's *Blueprint: How DNA Makes Us Who We Are* explains how polygenic scores aggregate many tiny statistical associations into probabilistic prediction for an operationalized trait. The memorable model is **gold dust, not nuggets**: there need be no "individualism gene." Minute influences involving autonomy, reactance, affiliation, conformity, authority, shared intentionality, property, impersonal trust, or group self-transcendence could combine into different propensities without determining any individual.

Haidt's account of human groupishness makes room for biologically relevant gene–culture change over historical rather than only prehistoric timescales, while Plomin supplies the diffuse architecture and a possible future measurement instrument. These claims are compatible: a distribution assembled from many tiny effects can drift slowly across generations while producing historically rapid change—potentially over comparatively few generations if selection pressures are strong and stable—relative to geological or deep evolutionary time.

Polygenic scores would not cause that drift. At most, valid future scores could help detect or predict it. No source cited here supplies a validated polygenic score for individualism versus collectivism, shows that such a score changed in medieval or early-modern Europe, or demonstrates that it caused the Renaissance, Enlightenment, or Counter-Enlightenment.

Between-population and historical inference is especially difficult. Population structure, ancestry, indirect genetic effects, assortative mating, environment, measurement drift, and poor cross-population portability can all create misleading patterns. See "Polygenic scores: prediction versus explanation" and "Polygenic scoring accuracy varies across the genetic ancestry continuum".

19.5 The collar-malfunction hypothesis: real individuality and the homo-simplex limit

The strongest recipient-side extension should again be stated before it is qualified:

> **Real individuality may have originated through partial malfunctions of the homo-duplex machinery. Variations that weakened, narrowed, exposed, or interrupted the local bigOther's control created openings in which the main CPU could become a more independent source of judgment. European individualist institutions may then have made some of these initially anomalous phenotypes viable, useful, and possibly selectable.**

This is an **originating strong speculation**, not an established evolutionary, genetic, developmental, or clinical account. The originating phrase that some collar variation "was not meant to be" uses the design stance in an evolutionary sense: the variation departs from the affective coordination function for which the machinery is hypothesized to have been selected. It does not posit a conscious designer. Nor does it imply that every departure is a disease or that an ancestral function remains adaptive in every later niche. A loss relative to one coordination regime can become an exaptation or adaptation in another.

The originating definition is correspondingly narrower than visible individuality or an avowed individualist doctrine:

> **Real individuality is the acceptance of rules on the level of the main CPU, with comparatively little automatic emotional government by the collar.**

The expression does not make private interest the sole objective of conduct. Neither does it mean normlessness, egoism, antisociality, mere reactance, or the absence of shared law. The proposed person may accept demanding impersonal rules because they can be understood, tested, and endorsed without their binding force depending primarily upon shame, sacred horror, collective excitement, or an experienced inner social presence.

One phenotype, several possible malfunctions **Loose collar** is too narrow to name the whole hypothesis. It describes one observable result, not its mechanism. The wireless collar contains a receiver, an installed mythological lens and its classification operations, affective outputs, actuation upon attention and conduct, jurisdictional routing, and networked transmission. These are functional distinctions inside the analogy, not claims that separately identified anatomical modules have been discovered:

```
social and symbolic signals
             ↓
receiver → classification through the mythological lens
             ↓
      affect generation
             ↓
```

```
influence on attention, motivation, judgment, and conduct
             ↕
     CPU observation and possible control

jurisdiction gates what enters the pathway
transmission returns local classifications to the field
```

Several different departures could produce outwardly similar independence:

Candidate malfunction	Proposed change	Important rival or boundary
Attachment malfunction—the loose collar	Belonging, approval, rejection, and anticipated judgment bind the person less tightly.	Weak attachment can also produce isolation or incapacity for durable trust.
Receiver malfunction	Consensus, authority, ritual, and collective emotion generate unusually little resonance.	Low response may instead reflect unfamiliar signals, distrust of one source, or deliberate resistance.
Classification malfunction	Social differences are perceived but do not reliably become sacred/profane, honourable/shameful, or loyal/treacherous classifications.	The lens may be differently programmed rather than weak.
Affective malfunction	A classification occurs without the expected guilt, shame, pride, fear, reverence, or disgust.	Low report can conceal strong nonverbal affect or strategic self-presentation.
Actuation malfunction	The affect occurs but weakly redirects attention, reasoning, motivation, or conduct.	Strong inhibition or competing motives can produce the same behavior.
Jurisdiction malfunction	The collar fails to extend its authority across the culturally expected range of life.	A lifted program may deliberately impose bounded jurisdiction; that is design, not malfunction.
Encapsulation malfunction—the open debug port	The collar remains active but no longer conceals its operation completely from the main CPU.	Development, disciplined introspection, or cultural instruction may create inspectability without inherited malfunction.
Network malfunction	The person receives or retransmits collective affect with unusually low gain.	Network position, social exclusion, or a weak surrounding field may account for the apparent trait.

The phenotype is therefore a vector rather than one scalar “collar strength.” Relevant dimensions include affective gain, attachment, field susceptibility, actuation, jurisdiction, opacity, inspectability, controllability, and transmission. They can vary independently and by domain or situation. Strong CPU oversight is not itself a collar malfunction, although it may exploit an open debug port. Deliberately bounded jurisdiction and trained resistance to collective pressure likewise must not be relabelled as defects merely because they resemble one malfunction profile.

Most importantly:

> **Malfunction is not yet individuality. It creates an opening.**

A broken or attenuated collar can yield social blindness, impulsiveness, opportunism, predation, paralysis, or inability to cooperate. The proposed real- individuality phenotype requires a capable CPU and a viable institutional ecology:

```
partial collar malfunction or unusual inspectability
+ capacity to understand, test, and revise rules
+ CPU-level acceptance of impersonal, reality-corrigible constraints
+ institutions able to coordinate without intense affective conformity
= candidate real individuality
```

Law, property, contract, reliable procedure, protected dissent, and impersonal office could externalize part of the coordination once supplied by intense bigOther attachment. They would not remove culture or make shared programming unnecessary. They could make some attenuated phenotypes less costly and sometimes advantageous.

Kant and the open debug port Kant supplies a possible case of inspectability, not evidence of a weak bigOther. His inner tribunal and doubled personality may indicate a powerful moral presence combined with unusual reflective access to it. The judge remains authoritative and duty remains binding, yet the judging process becomes available for description as accuser, accused, counsel, judge, *zwiefache Persönlichkeit*, and *doppeltes Selbst*.

The collar-malfunction interpretation asks whether an ordinarily sealed co-processor became unusually transparent:

```
opaque collar classification
-> verdict arrives as simply "my" obvious judgment

possible encapsulation malfunction
-> the judging process appears as an internal other
-> the CPU can observe and verbalize the operative rule
-> inspection, testing, and eventual debugging become possible
```

Kant may therefore represent a **high-gain but unusually transparent homo duplex**: high moral-affective authority, low opacity, high inspectability, and not necessarily high controllability. Seeing the judge does not mean escaping its authority. His philosophical achievement could be an early extraordinary act of debugging without showing that he possessed a low-gain phenotype.

This comparison remains a project-generated hypothesis. Kant explains conscience through autonomous practical reason, not a culturally programmed co-processor. His texts cannot establish his genotype, the developmental origin of his introspection, a European distributional change, or a causal path from inspectability to individualism. Rumination, scrupulosity, internal conflict, and paralysis are possible costs of the same apparent opening; philosophical productivity is not its necessary result.

Distribution, pseudo-simplex, and the limit case The "Quantum Mechanics of Psychology" supplies the intended statistical form. Psychological capacities and functional profiles may be distributed across persons. The claim concerns central tendencies, combinations, rare tails, thresholds, and changed distributions, not one invariant type expressed identically in everyone and not literal quantum equations.

The authoritative Culture Mechanics architecture remains homo duplex with one fully occupied PCI slot. A malfunctioning card can remain the only card in that slot; full occupancy concerns the exclusivity of the operative weave, not identical output strength or perfect operation of every pathway. This permits several speculative positions without quietly multiplying local bigOthers:

Position	Proposed architecture	Status here
Low-gain or otherwise attenuated homo duplex	One local bigOther and one operative lens remain, but one or more functions exert unusually weak control.	A candidate rare phenotype consistent with single-slot exclusivity.
Debuggable homo duplex	The local bigOther remains effective, but its operation is unusually inspectable by the main CPU.	Kant supplies a possible phenomenological case, not biological proof.
Pseudo-simplex	Several functions are so attenuated that conduct appears CPU-dominated although a distinct bigOther still adds explanatory value.	A measurement warning: outward independence does not establish absence.
True homo simplex	A functionally distinct local bigOther adds no explanatory value.	A limiting hypothesis and prospective defeat condition, not an accepted exception to the present theory.

If living or historical humans were established as true homo simplex, the universal scope of the authoritative homo-duplex architecture would have to be revised. The term must therefore not be smuggled into the theory merely because a person reports little guilt, resists consensus, or reasons explicitly about rules. High-field conditions, intimate relationships, threats to identity, ritual, reputation, and moral injury might reveal a functioning collar that calm, impersonal settings do not.

Doctrinal bifurcation, first-order recapture, and libertarian rarity The originating hypothesis links recipient variation to a recurring political failure:

> **As long as a doctrine continues to rely on a strong bigOther, it can drift back into first-order mechanical solidarity among people with fully functional collars, while failing to hold at all among people with severe collar malfunctions.**

The middle path is narrower. A person must have enough reflective capability and institutional support to accept impersonal rules at CPU level, while affective attachment, classification, and field gain are sufficiently attenuated or inspectable that the current output, leader, party, or enemy does not become the final sacred object. The proposed bifurcation is:

```
same abstract doctrine
× recipient architecture
× institutional scaffolding
× crisis and power
→ first-order recapture, CPU-centred stability, or non-uptake
```

First-order recapture does not mean that a lifted generator produced a detailed rule. It means binding force migrated from the corrigible generator to its current outputs, interpreters, representatives, or enemies. Nor does high-gain homo duplex make recapture inevitable. A strongly *beseelt* lifted order can make reality correction, bounded jurisdiction, loyal opposition, and institutional succession emotionally sacred. The hypothesis concerns a risk conditional on what receives finality, not a theorem that strong feeling is primitive.

The speculative political corollary is deliberately dangerous:

> **Libertarianism may remain electorally small partly because it fits a rare receiver architecture: enough collar malfunction to resist affective collective capture, but enough CPU capability, rule commitment, and institutional trust to cooperate without it.**

This is an **inverted-U hypothesis**, not "more malfunction makes a person more libertarian." Too little attenuation may leave collective sacredness dominant. Some intermediate combinations may support impersonal law, property, contract, and voluntary association. Severe attenuation without trust, foresight, self-command, reciprocity, or institutions may produce isolation, opportunism, non-uptake, or incapacity for durable cooperation rather than liberty.

Iyer, Koleva, Graham, Ditto, and Haidt's study of self-identified libertarians is neighbouring evidence, not confirmation of the mechanism. Across large web-based samples, the authors report weaker intuitions on most measured moral foundations but stronger liberty intuitions, less emotionality, and preference for weaker, less-binding social relationships; they explicitly state that causal conclusions remain unavailable. Those findings do not measure a local bigOther, malfunction, genetics, CPU control, or electoral viability.

An important counterexample comes from Jetten, Postmes, and McAuliffe's "We're all individuals": highly identified members can display individualist behaviour precisely by conforming to an individualist group norm. Outward individualism can therefore be strong first-order solidarity in individualist costume. Libertarian groups can likewise develop sacred founders, purity tests, enemies, and status hierarchies; their policy vocabulary does not establish low-gain homo duplex.

Electoral smallness is especially weak evidence. Electoral systems, strategic voting, coalition structure, party organization, national history, campaign resources, issue bundling, definitions of *libertarian*, and libertarian preferences inside major parties can all suppress a separate party vote. A serious test would measure attachment, affective classification, field susceptibility, actuation, jurisdiction, inspectability, CPU rule endorsement, trust, and cooperation separately; compare libertarians with equally individualist members of other traditions; and test whether the predicted intermediate profile survives demographic, institutional, and cultural controls.

The complete strong evolutionary proposal is:

```
standing developmental and possibly polygenic variation
-> rare differences in collar gain, coupling, jurisdiction, or opacity
-> some partial malfunctions create room or access for CPU judgment
-> Christian, legal, commercial, and constitutional institutions
   make selected variations more viable
-> expression, training, migration, status, partner choice,
   assortative mating, and possibly differential reproduction
-> a changed distribution of low-gain or inspectable homo-duplex phenotypes
```

```
-> stronger resonance with individualist institutions and mythology
-> possible far-tail approach toward pseudo-simplex
-> true homo simplex remains an unestablished limit and falsifier
```

This staircase does not show that Europe invented the human capacity for individuality or produced a new human essence. Cultural permission, developmental training, institutional scaffolding, selective migration, and biological selection can produce the same visible historical phenotype and may interact. The strongest version proposes a population-distribution novelty, not a categorical European type.

19.6 Chimp, bee, and the struggle for *Deutungshoheit*

The genetic branch may help explain not only differential receptivity but the ferocity of conflict between individualist and collectivist programmes. Haidt's percentages remain metaphorical, yet they supply three idealized normative poles:

Idealized aspiration	Desired social form
Toward "100% chimp"	Maximum individual sovereignty; collective agency is distrusted or reduced to instrumental coordination.
Accepting "90% chimp / 10% bee"	Individual sovereignty remains primary while bounded collective identification and solidarity are accepted as necessary human capacities.
Toward "100% bee"	The person should be absorbed into a sacred collective consciousness and act primarily through the big Other—the "drops of water in a clear pond" image.

These are aspirations, not literal biological types, genomic diagnoses, or exhaustive descriptions of Enlightenment and Marxist traditions. An individualist still depends upon shared programming for rights, markets, science, contract, and law. A Marxist remains a biological individual even when a mythology demands that personal judgment, property, loyalty, and identity be subordinated to a collectively enacted true consciousness.

Originating historical extension: Part of the European population may have become increasingly disposed toward autonomy, impersonal cooperation, property, and individual sovereignty, while another part remained more strongly attracted to collective integration. As inherited religious solidarity weakened, the latter could experience the change not primarily as liberation but as atomization and a painful God-shaped hole. Its members may also have been unusually capable of recognizing the loss of collective meaning and constructing successor mythologies. The Counter-Enlightenment, Marxism, and related systems can then be read partly as a rebellion against the social world produced by individualization and as attempts to recover total bee-mode in the language of a future true consciousness. This is the originating author's strong interpretation, not an established genomic account of political affiliation or a claim about every adherent.

The originating hypothesis is that dispositional variation makes the struggle over *Deutungshoheit* existential. The rivals do not contest only a policy. They contest which mode of human existence will control the shared interpretive environment and which subject—the differentiated person or the collective true consciousness—will be treated as morally real:

```
polygenic and developmental dispositional variation
-> differential resonance with individualist or collectivist mythology
-> self-selection into institutions, partners, occupations, and media
-> rival attempts to control the big Other and its Deutungshoheit
-> schools, laws, status systems, and institutions reward one orientation
-> changed cultural and possibly biological selection pressures
-> feeds back into later dispositional distributions
```

Control of *Deutungshoheit* determines which disposition is named mature, scientific, compassionate, selfish, oppressive, backward, or pathological. The conflict can therefore be at once an expression of existing differences, a fight to construct the cultural environment, and a possible part of the selection mechanism affecting later generations. The communist-ownership interpretation in "Enlightenment architecture and collectivist counter-construction" gives that conflict a concrete material jurisdiction.

19.7 Tests, alternatives, and failure conditions

The genetic hypothesis should remain auxiliary and high-risk. A valid programme would need, at minimum:

1. a precise and non-circular phenotype distinguishing individual sovereignty, real individuality, social affiliation, conformity, dominance, shared intentionality, first-order collectivism, antisociality, and mere reactance;
2. preregistered, replicated, within-family genetic associations rather than a score reverse-engineered to fit political categories;
3. evidence of portability and measurement invariance across times and populations;
4. ancient-DNA or longitudinal evidence capable of distinguishing biological change from migration, institutional formation, and cultural expression;
5. historically resolved evidence connecting variation in Church kinship exposure and regional selection ecologies to the predicted intermediate outcomes;
6. a causal bridge from disposition to partner choice, status, fertility, migration, institutions, and intellectual history;
7. and evidence that cultural, demographic, and media explanations do not already exhaust the pattern.

The collar-malfunction extension creates additional discriminators. Research would have to separate:

- affective gain from actuation, field susceptibility, jurisdiction, opacity, inspectability, controllability, and transmission rather than infer one latent "collar strength" from public conformity;
- a stable recipient disposition from a differently programmed lens, low trust in one authority, social exclusion, strategic self-presentation, a weak surrounding field, or deliberately trained self-authorship;
- CPU-level endorsement of an impersonal rule from compliance, post-hoc rationalization, reactance, and advantage-seeking;
- an open debug port from retrospective philosophical language that merely redescribes an otherwise opaque process;
- partial malfunction from clinical conditions and from morally or socially valuable bounded jurisdiction;
- and pseudo-simplex behavior from the absence of a functionally distinct bigOther.

The first-order-recapture and libertarian-rarity branches add further burdens:

- locate whether finality and affect attach to a meta-rule, a current output, an authorized interpreter, a party, or an enemy rather than infer order level from political vocabulary;
- distinguish low-gain or inspectable homo duplex from conformity to an individualist group norm;
- model libertarian support inside larger parties, strategic voting, electoral systems, organization, and issue bundling before treating vote share as a prevalence estimate;
- test the predicted inverted-U rather than a monotonic malfunction story; and
- show that the same abstract doctrine bifurcates by measured receiver architecture under comparable institutional and crisis conditions.

Repeated measures would need to compare calm and high-field settings, impersonal rules and identity-bearing conflicts, private judgment and visible consensus, ordinary mistakes and morally charged transgressions, and verbal report with affective and behavioral response. Developmental, adoption, twin, longitudinal, migration, and historically resolved population evidence could then help distinguish inheritance, socialization, institutional selection, and gene–culture coevolution. None of these methods by itself would identify a bigOther or validate the complete collar decomposition.

The strong version loses support if stable dispositional or genomic measures fail to predict mythology receptivity beyond ancestry, demographics, institutions, and self-report; if the proposed regional chronology is wrong; if marriage exposure does not predict the intermediate kinship and institutional changes; or if cultural activation and selective migration explain the visible phenotype without directional biological change. The collar-malfunction extension specifically loses support if its proposed dimensions cannot be distinguished empirically; if low affect, low conformity, and reflective access do not predict different responses; if Kant-like inspectability is explained adequately by learned philosophical practice without a recipient-side difference; or if a unitary-mind account explains the observations without loss while the proposed second processor adds no risky prediction.

Failure would weaken or defeat the genetic branch without defeating the broader Culture Mechanics account. That modularity is essential: polygenic speculation and the collar-malfunction extension must not become hidden load-bearing premises of the media history. Conversely, evidence for low-gain or inspectable homo duplex would not by itself establish genetic change, European uniqueness, or true homo simplex.

The originating account also proposes this branch as one possible explanation for why exporting democratic institutions sometimes fails. That extension is more demanding still. Institutional history, colonialism, state capacity,

security, wealth, education, kinship, religion, and prior constitutional experience are powerful alternatives. The corresponding theory claim is a prospective fit hypothesis, not a warrant for ranking populations or treating any individual as biologically incapable of democracy; see "Democracy export as a resonance problem" in *Mythology Construction*.

20. From clan immediacy to very-small-group Babelization

The dangerous claim should be stated before its evidential layers are separated:

> **Dense kinship, a shared clan programme, and densely coupled local bigOthers may once have made immediate mutual understanding more common within the clan while concentrating the sharpest differences between clans. Kinship widening then relocated more human difference into ordinary relationships and rewarded explicit cultural interfaces for cooperation among unlike persons. Durkheim describes the later continuation of this differentiation. His religion of Humanity can be read as a constructed bridge after empirical sameness has receded. If that bridge and its lifted institutional supports become too thin, human differentiation may descend into very-small-group Babelization: material connection among tiny internally intelligible islands without sufficient translation, common standing, or legitimate procedure between them. Individual Babelization is the ultra-extreme case in which the remaining island approaches one person.**

This is a **project synthesis** joining situated observation, the kinship-field hypothesis, the Christian-architecture branch, Durkheim's explicit account of differentiation, and a further Culture Mechanics projection. Durkheim does not propose the clan mechanism, close-kin-marriage pathway, genetic extension, or future Babelization. The social arc also does not require the strong genetic and collar-malfunction hypotheses in the preceding chapter.

20.1 The situated opening: similarity lowers translation cost

The originating observation came first from relationships rather than historical data. One of the author's children is regularly described as a "mini-me." With this child, the author experiences an unusually immediate connection: half-sentences can be enough. With another child, the author "speaks a different language"; the connection is no less loving, but it requires more translation. Stories from other parents suggested that this contrast was not necessarily unique.

Management supplied a second observation. As a colleague, one can accept that another person completes a task differently. Responsibility for that person's work forces an attempt to reconstruct how the person saw the situation, and then differences that had seemed superficial can appear fundamental. The originating zeroth-order assumption—that people are basically like me, with higher-order variations—gave way to the verdict that people can differ even at the **zeroth-order approximation**. Aphantasia is a clean illustration: speakers can use the same language of "seeing" an image while living through categorically different experiences.

A recurring thought while looking at strangers in the underground condensed the problem:

> **Given how profoundly different people are, how does the world work at all?**

These statements are **situated testimony and originating interpretation**. A *Zeitzeuge* is not a calibrated instrument, but situatedness creates access. The observations motivate the hypothesis that interpersonal similarity affects translation cost; they do not establish its population frequency, causes, heritability, historical distribution, or social value.

The bounded mechanism is statistical, not typological:

```
recurrent dispositions within a kin network
+ shared upbringing and practical experience
+ a common clan programme implemented by local bigOthers
-> a higher frequency of high-fit relationships
-> lower average internal translation cost
```

A clan is not a collection of copies. Close kin can be opaque, hostile, or radically different; unrelated persons can understand one another immediately. The proposal concerns the distribution of matching configurations and the average cost of translation, not guaranteed transparency. Interpersonal immediacy is not fusion, cultural interoperability, agreement, or truth: two people can understand one another fluently while jointly misreading reality or excluding everyone else.

20.2 The clan-immediacy hypothesis

Originating hypothesis: Long-running endogamy could combine recurrent dispositional clusters with shared roles, stories, rituals, sanctions, and material circumstances. Within such a clan, a comparatively thick common component might dominate a first approximation. Coordination would rely less on explicit translation because participants could more often anticipate what a situation meant, what another person felt, and which response the clan expected.

The possible cost appears at the perimeter:

```
high within-clan fit + one thick local programme
-> interpersonal immediacy inside the clan
-> little routine practice translating profound difference

different kin cluster + different thick local programme
-> a sharp discontinuity at the clan boundary
-> suspicion, misrecognition, feud, or conflict becomes easier
```

The memorable contrast is:

> **The old clan may have possessed greater interpersonal immediacy but less intergroup interoperability. Modern society may possess less interpersonal immediacy but greater large-scale interoperability.**

This mechanism cannot by itself explain clan conflict. Resources, inherited injury, honour systems, political institutions, ecology, conquest, and strategic competition are powerful alternatives. Nor does common ancestry establish a shared operative programme or a distributed bigOther. The blood-subject hypothesis in the preceding chapter supplies one hard case in which kinship, corporate liability, and cultural subjecthood might have reinforced one another.

20.3 Kinship widening relocates difference

The marriage-field hypothesis now acquires a second, non-genetic interpretation. Repeated marriage beyond the close kin group does not create human difference. It changes where that difference is encountered:

```
endogamous clustering
-> many recurrent differences remain concentrated between groups

cross-kin marriage + mobility + non-kin association
-> more differences enter households, workplaces, towns, and institutions
-> unlike persons must coordinate in ordinary life
```

The loss of interpersonal immediacy can therefore create selection pressure for **cultural interfaces**: explicit speech, negotiation, contract, office, reputation, markets, impersonal law, appellate procedure, toleration, and rules for acting together without complete psychological agreement. Coordination moves from *we understand because we are alike* toward *we can cooperate because our interfaces translate, allocate jurisdiction, and limit what either may do to the other*.

Christianity may contribute on both sides of that transition. Its universal mythology supplies a relation that crosses lineage boundaries, while its inward faith, personal intention, conscience, and distinction between spiritual and temporal authority make differentiated persons more visible. The Christian differentiated-unity chapter develops that separate cultural and jurisdictional mechanism. The same historical movement may thus enlarge the common field while reducing the amount of concrete personality that participants must share.

This proposal must not turn exogamy into a one-cause history of modernity. State formation, cities, commerce, war, literacy, migration, professional institutions, and religious universalism can widen cooperation independently and can also cause kinship change. Exogamy can form larger alliances without producing individualism, impersonal law, or tolerance.

20.4 The stronger genetic extension: Haidt's fast-evolution opening

The social relocation mechanism above does not require genetic change. It proposes that kinship widening brings already existing human differences into more households and ordinary relationships. The stronger extension adds:

> **The same kinship, institutional, and cultural transformation may have altered the distribution of dispositions itself. Once widened social fields rewarded stranger cooperation, individual jurisdiction,**

impersonal office, contract, mobility, and reflective independence, selective migration, status, partner choice, assortative mating, fertility, and survival may have made some compatible polygenic configurations more common. Institutions would then be both cultural products of a changing population and selection environments that helped produce later populations.

Here **polygenic** uses the many-small-effects vocabulary introduced through Robert Plomin in "Gold dust, fast evolution, and measurement". A complex psychological disposition may reflect tiny statistical contributions from many genetic variants rather than one decisive gene. A **polygenic score** is the corresponding measurement device: it combines estimated variant associations into a probabilistic index for an operationalized trait or outcome. The underlying polygenic configuration, its distribution in a population, and a score constructed to estimate part of that variation are therefore not the same thing. A score could at most help detect or predict a distributional change; it would not cause it. No validated score for individualism, collar malfunction, or mythology receptivity is assumed.

This is the gene–culture feedback shared with Jonathan Haidt's argument in chapter 9 of *The Righteous Mind*. Haidt presents two linked propositions in his case for human groupishness: gene–culture coevolution means that cumulative cultural innovations can alter the adaptive value of human traits, and evolution can be fast enough for substantial change to occur within historically recent periods. The second proposition keeps the first open after prehistory. Culture Mechanics adopts that general two-stranded possibility:

```
inherited dispositional distribution
-> differential uptake and construction of culture
-> institutions, status systems, niches, and partner choices
-> altered migration, mating, fertility, survival, and prestige
-> changed cultural and possibly genetic selection pressures
-> later dispositional distribution
-> different resonance with mythologies and institutions
```


Haidt did not originate quantitative gene–culture coevolution, and Culture Mechanics does not inherit his complete multilevel-selection argument by using this bridge. More importantly, Haidt does not establish the Europe-specific extension proposed here. His principal target is evolved **groupishness**; his argument could support stronger tribal coordination as readily as weak-collar individuality. The following claims belong to Culture Mechanics:

- Western Christian marriage restrictions supplied a relevant historical intervention;
- widened kinship and impersonal institutions selected dispositions compatible with individual sovereignty and non-kin cooperation;
- a population-level shift contributed to European individualism;
- rare collar malfunctions or open debug ports formed part of the selected variation;
- and this change later contributed to Durkheimian differentiation or shrinking residual interoperability scale.

The extension must separate four processes that can look identical in later historical description:

1. **Gene flow and recombination:** exogamy disperses recurrent kin clusters and reshuffles existing variation without selecting a direction.
2. **Cultural activation and training:** institutions permit, reward, or teach conduct that an unchanged population could already produce.
3. **Selective sorting:** migration and assortative association concentrate dispositions geographically or institutionally without changing the total population distribution.
4. **Biological selection:** stable differences in partner choice, fertility, survival, or descendant success shift a later population distribution. The intentionally artificial punctuality example makes the proposed transition visible: if a culture classifies punctuality as respect, prospective partners may deselect chronically unpunctual people as disrespectful. That is partner selection, but it enters biological selection only if the classified difference is partly heritable and the pattern persistently changes mating, fertility, reproduction, or descendant distributions across generations.

Only the fourth is directional genetic evolution. The first can reduce local interpersonal immediacy merely by breaking up recurrent configurations. The second and third can make individuality macroscopically visible. None licenses an inference to genetic selection from Renaissance biographies, voting patterns, or present regional differences.

The complete historical extension is:

```
close-kin restrictions + cross-clan marriage
-> wider reproductive, social, and mythological mesh
```

```
-> greater everyday exposure to unlike persons
-> growing value of translation, contract, property, office, and impersonal law
-> cultural and institutional rewards for compatible dispositions
-> selective migration + status + partner choice + differential reproduction
-> possible polygenic distribution change over historical time
-> stronger average fit with some individualist and lifted institutions
-> further niche construction and selection
```
↻

The phrase **possible polygenic distribution change** is essential. In Plomin's gold-dust image, there need be no "individualism gene," and a mean shift need not reduce human diversity. Selection could change a mean, variance, covariance among dispositions, or the frequency of rare configurations. Population mixing can meanwhile relocate variation without changing any of those quantities.

The genetic branch is therefore stronger than the social arc in two senses. It asserts an additional causal layer, and it requires evidence capable of distinguishing inherited distributional change from training, permission, migration, assortment, and institutional selection. The detailed measurement problems, collar-malfunction boundary, and falsifiers remain in the genetic chapter, especially "Gold dust, fast evolution, and measurement" and its test catalogue.

20.5 Durkheim's differentiation mechanism

Durkheim supplies direct support for the later part of the arc. In "Individualism and the Intellectuals," pp. 51–52, he argues that larger territorial societies require more plastic traditions. Individual variations consequently escape older restraints and multiply. The division of labour then orients minds toward different parts of reality, so "the contents of consciousness differs from one person to another." To reverse the movement would require equalizing personalities, returning to older conformism, and arresting social expansion and division of labour.

The parallel with the originating underground question is striking. Durkheim asks how intellectual and moral community remains possible when persons increasingly inhabit different horizons. His proposed endpoint is not Babelization. It is a society in which rich common contents have dissolved until members have little left in common except their Humanity.

Durkheim therefore supports:

```
larger and more mobile society
+ plastic traditions
+ developed division of labour
-> freer individual variation
+ different cognitive horizons
-> increasingly person-specific contents of consciousness
```

He does **not** establish:

```
close-kin marriage -> interpersonal immediacy
exogamy -> relocation of psychological difference
European genetic drift -> greater zeroth-order difference
differentiation -> inevitable very-small-group or individual Babelization
```

Rousseau's averaging operation can now be historicized without being excused. Perhaps he observed a world in which a thicker common component still seemed analytically recoverable. Perhaps he mistook a local cultural and genealogical commonality for universal Humanity. Or perhaps the extraordinary legislator was needed to manufacture the common core that independent aggregation presupposed. The Rousseau–Durkheim comparison keeps these possibilities open.

20.6 Constructed Humanity as the last common bridge

Durkheim takes a constructive route beyond Rousseau's analytic averaging. When people are different even at the zeroth-order approximation, a sufficiently rich empirical human core may not be available for extraction. Like the ideal circle of pure geometry, the **human person in general** can instead be constructed by disregarding contingent differences and assigning every concrete instance full standing.

The proposition that society may have to teach, enact, and *einreden* people into experiencing is:

However profoundly different human beings are, every concrete person is a complete bearer of sacred human standing.

Humanism then functions as a purposeful mythology and an interoperability protocol. It is thin in shared first-order content, universal in span, and potentially strong in affective binding. Stories, education, declarations, rituals, and exemplary cases form its living cultural body. Rights, courts, due process, bounded authority, and the visible protection of unpopular outliers form the institutional skeleton that makes its promise socially real.

This is not a claim that Durkheim fabricated Humanity personally or that legal standing should depend upon empirical sameness. It is the project's interpretation of his sociological construction: as older common objects dissolve, society sacralizes an abstraction capable of protecting the concrete individual precisely when that person is unlike everyone else.

Durkheim's Humanity is therefore the proposed **last station before Babelization**, not Babelization's cause. It can sustain differentiated unity only while at least three conditions hold:

1. **Semantic reproduction:** people retain enough common understanding of what human standing protects.
2. **Affective reproduction:** violation of even an unpopular outlier continues to evoke the sacred prohibition Durkheim describes.
3. **Institutional embodiment:** procedures and offices reliably protect the person rather than merely repeating Humanist vocabulary.

Humanity can also be inverted. If the abstraction is agentified as a collective subject with interests superior to its concrete instances, "Humanity" can authorize consuming the person it was constructed to protect. Humanism then ceases to be the bridge and becomes a first-order recapture of it.

20.7 The projected boundary: very-small-group Babelization and the individual limit

Strong speculation: Historical differentiation may not be finished. If the contents of consciousness continue to diverge while shared translation, Humanist standing, and legitimate lifted procedures weaken, cultural interoperability may survive mainly inside very small groups while failing across the wider society.

The main originating projection is therefore **very-small-group Babelization**, not immediate atomization. Families, couples, friendship circles, local communities, or online niches may form tiny islands in which meanings remain comparatively translatable and belonging remains strong, while the interfaces between those islands cease to support a common cultural and political order. These examples identify possible scales, not a claim that every such group is internally interoperable.

The **residual interoperability scale**—intuitively, the **Babelization grain size**—describes the characteristic scale at which mutual intelligibility still operates:

```
large common culture
-> rival mass cultures
-> subcultures and local communities
-> very small mutually intelligible groups
-> the individual limit
```

This need not be one temporal staircase. Different domains can fragment at different scales, and tiny islands may remain linked for commerce or administration while lacking a shared moral or political world.

Individual Babelization remains the ultra-extreme limiting case: no stable surrounding group shares enough of the person's operative meanings for reliable recognition, translation, and coordination. Two false equations must remain blocked:

```
individuality ≠ Babelization
human difference ≠ interoperability failure
```

The person does not become cultureless or homo simplex. Single-slot exclusivity still holds, the person retains one operative weave, and the local bigOther may remain powerful. What approaches one is the size of the remaining interoperable island.

The proposed movement is:

```
increasingly person-specific experience, language, and moral classification
+ thinning shared Humanist meaning and affect
+ declining trust in common procedures
```

```
+ institutions experienced as alien programmes
-> translation costs exceed the effective shared lifted surface
-> society fragments into tiny internally intelligible islands
-> some persons cannot enter or sustain even one stable island
-> individual Babelization becomes the limiting possibility
```

People can remain materially connected by supply chains, platforms, law, and administration throughout this movement. They may use the same words without sharing referents, recognize no mutually legitimate way to decide, and experience another person's claim as either unintelligible or an external attempt at programming.

The originating extension concerning the so-called loneliness pandemic is:

> **Loneliness may sometimes be the subjective experience of failed cultural interoperability: being surrounded by people without inhabiting a sufficiently shared world with them.**

On this hypothesis, loneliness can increase despite abundant physical and digital contact:

```
shared cultural surface thins
-> fewer relationships supply reliable mutual recognition
-> ordinary connection requires greater translation effort
-> repeated misrecognition, failed repair, or withdrawal
-> inability to enter or sustain a small interoperable island
-> loneliness amid continuing contact
```

This is a **possible observable consequence and sensor**, not proof of the historical mechanism. Bereavement, household structure, mobility, ageing, illness, disability, urban form, work patterns, platform design, economic conditions, clinical mechanisms, and simple lack of contact can generate loneliness without Babelization. Conversely, very-small-group Babelization can produce intense belonging and little loneliness inside a surviving island while increasing distance and hostility toward outsiders.

The recurrent loop therefore has two branches:

```
wider translation failure
-> search for immediate recognition
-> tightly synchronized micro-group or surrogate clan
-> restored local immediacy + sharper boundaries against outsiders
-> very-small-group Babelization deepens

or:

wider translation failure
+ no accessible or stable high-fit micro-group
-> individual Babelization + loneliness becomes possible
```

The rival future is equally important. Modern persons may be less immediately intelligible to one another precisely because they have become better practised at bridging difference. A society can combine greater psychological variation with stronger translation, plural jurisdictions, Humanist standing, and reality-correcting lifted rules:

```
greater difference
+ learned translation and epistemic humility
+ sacred standing of the concrete person
+ corrigible common procedures and bounded jurisdictions
-> differentiated unity above the anti-Babel floor
```

The arc is therefore branching, not a philosophy of inevitable progress or decline:

```
clan immediacy
  -> thick local similarity / weak cross-clan interoperability
  -> kinship widening + Christian universalism + larger institutions
  -> heterogeneous everyday society
  -> explicit translation + impersonal and lifted interfaces
  -> Durkheimian differentiation
       ├─ Humanism remains semantically, affectively, and institutionally alive
       │    -> plural interoperability among profoundly different persons
       └─ the shared surface thins, inverts, or fragments
```

```
-> very-small-group Babelization
-> local belonging + wider re-clanification
-> for some, individual Babelization and loneliness
```

20.8 Tests, alternatives, and falsifiers

The arc earns a place in the speculative history by producing discriminating questions:

- Do dense kin networks show lower average interpersonal translation costs after shared upbringing, language, class, and contact are separated from genetic relatedness?
- Does endogamy increase within-group mutual prediction while increasing discontinuity at group boundaries, or do institutions and repeated interaction explain both effects better?
- Does kinship widening precede greater psychological heterogeneity within households and associations, and does it increase reliance upon contract, procedure, office, and impersonal adjudication?
- Did the widened institutions create stable differences in migration, status, partner choice, fertility, survival, or descendant success associated with the proposed dispositions, rather than merely train or sort an unchanged population?
- Can ancient DNA, within-family designs, demographic records, or prospective disposition measures distinguish actual distributional change from gene flow, cultural activation, assortment, and selective migration?
- Do division of labour, mobility, and differentiated expertise reduce shared first-order content while increasing reliance upon common meta-rules?
- Are modern people better at translation across profound difference, merely more exposed to it, or increasingly isolated by it?
- Does Humanist standing remain strongest when protecting an extreme and unpopular outlier, or does it disappear exactly where empirical resemblance ends?
- When interoperability weakens, does the residual interoperability scale shrink from mass domains through subcultures toward very small groups, or do people instead learn better translation?
- Do people inside stable micro-islands report strong belonging alongside high cross-group semantic distance, as very-small-group Babelization predicts?
- After contact volume and demographic, material, technological, and clinical alternatives are controlled, do failed recognition, translation cost, repair failure, and unstable micro-group membership predict loneliness?
- Can semantic agreement, affective commitment, procedural legitimacy, and institutional protection vary independently, as the three-condition model predicts?

The clan-immediacy pathway is weakened if close kin are no easier to understand than comparable non-kin; if exogamy does not relocate heterogeneity into ordinary relationships; or if state formation, markets, urbanization, schooling, and shared institutions explain the observed transition without an additional kinship pathway. The Babelization projection is weakened if person-specific differentiation stabilizes while common meanings and procedures remain robust, if increasing difference reliably improves rather than strains interoperability, or if no contraction in the residual interoperability scale can be detected. The genetic extension is weakened if the institutional niche produced no stable trait-related differences in mating or descendant success, if genomic and demographic evidence shows no predicted distributional change, or if cultural training and sorting explain the phenotype without biological selection. The loneliness extension is weakened if semantic-affective mismatch and unstable micro-group membership add no explanatory or predictive value beyond objective isolation and the named rival causes. The Humanist-bridge claim is weakened if abstract rights work equally well without shared affective standing, public embodiment, or protection of outliers.

Evidence against any link should remove that link rather than be absorbed by the whole arc. The social mechanism can survive failure of the genetic extension; the Durkheimian differentiation mechanism can survive failure of the kinship explanation; and increasing differentiation can be real without very-small-group or individual Babelization becoming its destination.

21. The whole causal staircase

The proposed sequence can now be seen at once:

Stage	Proposed change	Culture-mechanical consequence
Biological capacity	Human shared intentionality and groupish self-transcendence	A *we* can become represented, felt, and normatively binding

Stage	Proposed change	Culture-mechanical consequence
Ancestral constraint	Small bands, slow travel, scarce assembly, face-to-face correction	Collective beings remain bounded and expensive
Strong speculation: agentified older subjectivity	Some cultures may give divine, ancestral, and role-based agent-models more immediate authority than a continuous autobiographical *I*	Bicameral-like enactment and episodic god-as-multi-mind-self become possible without implying several local bigOthers
Priestly infrastructure	Specialists preserve, teach, activate, and enforce mythology	Larger and longer-lived collective agents become possible
Christian differentiated-unity architecture	Individual call, inward faith and intention, cultural interoperability above the anti-Babel floor, differentiated unity, transcendent limits on worldly authority, spiritual–temporal differentiation, and protected ownership; Durkheim retrospectively calls Christianity a "restrained individualism"	Strong belonging becomes compatible with conscience, personal and household jurisdiction, divergent first-order lives, and worldly inquiry without requiring subjecthood absorption; individuality gains cultural space
Writing and print	Memory and replication separate partly from human carriers	Fidelity, reach, recurrence, and intellectual systematization increase
Auxiliary: kinship-field and liability transition	Western Christian restrictions on close-kin marriage repeatedly bridge reproductive, social, and mythological networks; overlapping obligations may weaken clans as unitary owners of blood debt	Clan closure and corporate liability may weaken while compensation, personal culpability, non-kin cooperation, and impersonal institutions become more useful
Project synthesis: difference enters ordinary relationships	Kinship widening, mobility, division of labour, and differentiated experience reduce reliance upon interpersonal immediacy	Explicit translation, Humanist standing, impersonal law, and lifted procedures can sustain plural interoperability; if their effective shared surface fails, the residual interoperability scale may shrink toward very small groups and, in the limiting case, one person
Auxiliary: regional selection and fast gene–culture feedback	Northern Italian and northwestern commercial ecologies reward, attract, train, sort, and perhaps differentially reproduce individualist dispositions; Haidt's fast-evolution argument supplies the general historical-timescale opening, not the Europe-specific result	Individuality becomes macroscopically visible; individualism and possibly polygenic dispositions become self-reinforcing if cultural activation and sorting are joined by actual differential reproduction
Auxiliary: collar-malfunction niche	Impersonal law, property, contract, protected dissent, and reliable procedure make some attenuated or unusually inspectable homo-duplex profiles more viable	Partial malfunction can create room for CPU judgment; with capability and institutional scaffolding it may contribute to real individuality, while pseudo-simplex and homo simplex remain boundary hypotheses
Jurisdictional comparison	Trade, travel, postal routes, and print make neighboring orders mutually observable	First-order rules appear bounded; rivalry or pressure for lifted coexistence becomes possible
Attempted reflexive mythology construction	Authors and institutions increasingly diagnose audiences, choose destinations, vary formulations, and revise from feedback	Mythology becomes a candidate purposive intervention surface inside, but never sovereign over, endogenous cultural selection

Stage	Proposed change	Culture-mechanical consequence
Privileged interpreter and doctrinal progeny	Exceptional insight is mythologized as access to the hidden interest of People, History, Humanity, Nation, Science, or Class; institutions reproduce the interpreter position	Claimed epistemic asymmetry can become jurisdiction, while recurring descendants expose an offspring profile that must be classified rather than excused or attributed automatically
Periodical public	Newspapers and pamphlets shorten the political feedback cycle	Secular mythologies compete and synchronize wider publics
Revolutionary resonance	Media, ritual, crisis, crowds, and coercion reinforce one another	A candidate modern *Resonanzkatastrophe* becomes visible
Broadcasting	Cheap receivers and simultaneous centralized voice	Nation-scale laser-like attention and leader-presence intensify
Thought reform	Participants become repeaters, confessors, monitors, and correction targets	The programme closes its loop around persons and peers
Platforms	Reciprocal signals become global, visible, quantified, and selected in real time	Manias can self-organize; local lasers and cultural interoperability breakdown (Babelization) can both accelerate
Planetary nervous infrastructure	Telecommunications, databases, sensors, institutions, technical decision routes, and effectors become increasingly connected	Radermacher's superorganismic coordination and control-bottleneck question become practically relevant without proving one global brain or controller
Generative AI	Persuasion, mutation, personalization, monitoring, routing, and activation become automated	Radermacher's separate queen/bottleneck and ant-state warning lines can be joined by the project into a coupling thermostat or alignment-sovereign possibility

The staircase is not a claim of monotonic progress. Technologies can be forgotten, states can collapse, publics can decouple, and open institutions can deliberately slow or partition feedback. Nor is the latest stage always the strongest. A small face-to-face cult can exert more total control over a person than a global platform. The claim is about the expanding feasible set and falling cost of scale. The three rows marked **Auxiliary** are a separately falsifiable recipient-side branch; the rest of the staircase does not require historical genetic change, a collar malfunction, or homo simplex.

22. Predictions, discriminators, and possible falsifiers

This story becomes useful only if it risks being wrong.

22.1 Transmission-cost predictions

- Holding crisis and doctrine roughly constant, lower reproduction cost and faster feedback should increase a mythology's spread, recurrence, or mutation rate.
- Simultaneous audiovisual broadcasting should increase temporal synchrony more than asynchronous print, while print may produce slower and more durable doctrinal standardization.
- Systems that make peer response visible should produce more conformity and common-mode error than otherwise similar systems that preserve independent judgment before aggregation.
- Human intermediaries should remain especially important where trust, ambiguity, ritual embodiment, and local sanction matter; pure "media effects" should be weaker there.

22.2 Resonance predictions

- Strong episodes should show positive feedback among emotional arousal, recurrent messaging, visible peer response, master-signifier convergence, suppression of counter-signals, and coordinated action.
- The same message introduced without crisis, trusted carriers, or reciprocal confirmation should often fail to synchronize.
- A successful coupling intervention should be able to change crowd mode by altering information independence, exposure, timing, network topology, or counter-signal availability without changing every participant's private belief.

22.3 Historical discriminators

- If revolutionary violence tracks fiscal, military, and institutional breakdown but not communication density, recurrence, ritual synchronization, or censorship, the media-resonance contribution is overstated.
- If receiver preparation, reciprocal feedback, common knowledge, nonlinear amplification, and macroscopic reorganization cannot be distinguished from ordinary crisis diffusion, the *Resonanzkatastrophe* classification fails even when the event remains historically catastrophic.
- If pre-1789 movements display the same secular universal mythology, periodical coupling, public scale, and successor-sacred order, the proposed takeoff must be moved earlier.
- If the categorical variants of revolutionary individualism show no recruitment or displacement advantage over accurate moderate variants under comparable incumbent resistance, the revolutionary-overshoot hypothesis is weakened.
- If changes in marriage radius do not precede or predict declining corporate target substitution, blood money, feud persistence, lineage jurisdiction, or sanctions for refusing vengeance, the proposed exogamy-to-personal-liability pathway should be abandoned even if broader kinship effects remain.
- If dense kinship does not predict lower interpersonal translation cost under comparable shared experience, or kinship widening does not relocate greater heterogeneity into ordinary relationships, the clan-immediacy pathway should be abandoned even if other exogamy effects remain.
- If increasing differentiation does not reduce shared first-order contents, increase reliance upon translation and common meta-rules, or create measurable interoperability strain, the projected route toward very-small-group and individual Babelization should be narrowed or abandoned.
- If shrinking residual interoperability scale, failed recognition, translation cost, repair failure, and unstable micro-group membership do not predict loneliness beyond objective isolation and rival demographic, material, technological, and clinical causes, the loneliness extension should be abandoned without discarding the Babelization mechanism.
- If apparent collar-malfunction profiles disappear after accounting for developmental practice, installed mythology, network position, institutional incentives, strategic conduct, and current field strength, the inherited recipient-side extension should be narrowed or abandoned even if cultural self-authorship remains real.
- If measured collar dimensions and CPU capability do not distinguish first-order recapture, stable impersonal cooperation, and non-uptake, the recipient-architecture bifurcation should be abandoned.
- If libertarian affiliation is predicted as well or better by conformity to an individualist group norm, electoral institutions, strategic voting, organization, or ordinary issue preference, the rarity-by-malfunction branch should be narrowed or abandoned.
- If the *Volksempfänger* did not materially change access, simultaneity, message recurrence, or perceived leader-presence after controlling for party and state coercion, its "hyperdrive" role should be reduced.
- If digital platforms mostly fragment attention without producing common-mode classifications and coordinated enforcement, cultural interoperability breakdown (Babelization) is a better model than laser synchronization at society scale.
- If the Christian elements identified here did no recurring work in resisting political sacralization, coerced sameness, or confiscation of personal jurisdiction, the person-preserving, anti-fusion branch should be narrowed or abandoned rather than protected by defining every countercase as non-Christian.
- If changes in ancient god-language track literary genre, political convention, or textual transmission without corresponding evidence of command attribution, weak autobiographical authorship, ritual activation, or distributed agency, the bicameral-like god-enactment branch should be narrowed or abandoned.

22.4 Agency and responsibility tests

- Distinguish discovery by cultural selection from deliberate engineering by looking for audience research, experiments, internal strategy, feedback metrics, message revision, and explicit suppression plans.

- Do not infer that a philosopher operated a later movement merely because the movement quoted the philosopher.
- For every claimed doctrinal descendant, distinguish entailment, authorization or affordance, selection, concealed causal design, and appropriation or inversion; allow mixed relations.
- Where doctrinal lying by omission is alleged, look for prior causal knowledge, private predictions, audience engineering, institutional implementation, material non-disclosure, and resistance to correction rather than infer intent from bad outcomes alone.
- Treat repeated party-state cases as partially dependent where they share Soviet organizational templates, sponsors, conflicts, or geopolitical pressures.
- Do not let distributed causation erase responsibility: editors, officials, organizers, engineers, and participants can make consequential choices even when nobody designed the whole resonance system.
- Test the Radermacher bridge in stages: distributed knowledge, functioning institutional nervous system, higher-order performance, practical control bottleneck, operative collective agency, and subjecthood absorption require different observations and must not be inferred as one automatic ladder.
- Where an AI control plane is alleged, identify the actual sensors, models, source-ranking rules, decision interfaces, resources, effectors, institutional dependencies, refusal routes, and correction paths rather than infer sovereignty from technical capability or similar outputs alone.
- Compare the declared destination with the actual successor. Divergence should be attributed among receiver reinterpretation, incumbent resistance, institutional filtering, rival intervention, unintended consequence, and reality rather than hidden under a generic claim of engineering success or failure.

22.5 Strong falsifiers

The broad story would be seriously weakened if:

- human shared intentionality proved unnecessary to the strongest proposed cases;
- changes in communication cost and feedback showed no reliable relation to scale, synchrony, durability, or common-mode error;
- supposedly synchronized episodes were explained adequately by independent individual incentives with no field back-action;
- historical actors did not show the predicted classifications, reciprocal monitoring, sacredness, or correction loops;
- the proposed receiver–order mismatches were reconstructed only from doctrines written after the fact and left no independent trace in prior practices, institutions, grievances, or dispositions;
- corporate liability and personal/public liability changed independently of the proposed marriage-mediated pathway, with state formation, commerce, group size, wealth, conquest, or legal professionalization providing an adequate account;
- or the framework could label every possible outcome—unity, fragmentation, dormancy, loss, or revival—as confirmation after the fact.

The last danger is especially important. A theory that explains both synchronization and its absence without advance discriminators has become a vocabulary, not a causal model.

23. Compact final thesis

The speculative history can be reduced to one claim:

> **Humans are not merely individual chimp-like agents who occasionally coordinate. We also possess a bee-like capacity to enter a binding *we*. For most of history, large-scale use of that capacity required an expensive human infrastructure of priests, missionaries, teachers, organizers, rituals, and institutions. A separate strong speculation, developed through the Jaynes–Bach bridge, proposes that some older cultures may have made divine and ancestral agent-models more authoritative than a continuous autobiographical *I* and used ritual to awaken episodic gods-as-multi-mind-selves; the historical media story does not depend on that proposal. Christianity is proposed as a special architecture within that history: it held differentiated persons in one shared order above the cultural- interoperability floor (anti-Babel floor), located the absolute beyond the terrestrial collective, made inward faith, intention, and personal answerability morally decisive, differentiated spiritual from temporal authority, protected personal and household ownership, and thus opened space for individuality without abolishing strong belonging. Durkheim supplies a supporting genealogy for this cultural branch: Christianity was a "restrained individualism" whose inward turn and jurisdictional differentiation were continued in modern**

Humanism. He does not establish the separate kinship, genetic, or collar-malfunction mechanisms. The Rousseau–Durkheim comparison then separates two attempts to find "the I without the me": Rousseau analytically extracts a common decision signal from empirical wills, while Durkheim constructively installs an ideal Humanity whose standing constrains collective decisions and protects even the outlier. The Humanist construction remains person-preserving only while Humanity does not become an agentified abstraction authorized to consume its concrete instances. That proper architecture could be ponerogenically captured, but subjecthood-absorptive or total-fusion misuse had to neutralize or invert its internal boundaries. The project then extends the history from clan immediacy to a branching future. Dense kinship and shared programming may have increased the frequency of high-fit relationships inside clans while leaving sharper discontinuities between them. Kinship widening relocated more difference into households and ordinary cooperation, rewarding explicit translation, contract, impersonal office, and law. Durkheim independently describes the later effect of scale and division of labour: minds face different horizons and consciousness becomes increasingly person-specific. His constructed Humanity is read here as the last common bridge across that difference. If its semantic, affective, and institutional supports remain alive, profound individuality can coexist with plural interoperability. If differentiation outruns those supports, the primary projected failure is very-small-group Babelization: tiny internally intelligible islands coexist with wider semantic decoupling and re-clanification. Individual Babelization is the ultra-extreme limiting case in which a person cannot enter or sustain even one such island. Some phenomena described as a loneliness pandemic may be the experiential consequence of that movement—contact without a sufficiently shared world—but loneliness is a possible sensor rather than proof and has powerful rival causes. This arc is a project synthesis and strong projection; Durkheim does not establish its kinship mechanism, residual scale, loneliness extension, or future endpoint. Media technologies progressively automated and cheapened parts of that infrastructure. Philosophical mythologies and political organizations could therefore recruit larger populations, repeat signals more densely, observe and correct responses more quickly, suppress rivals more effectively, and sometimes drive a prepared receiver–order mismatch into a resonance catastrophe. This history contains endogenous mythology formation and attempts at purposive mythology construction. Deliberate actors can choose destinations and intervene in the assembly-language layer; whether they can reliably construct the released successor remains an open research question because receivers, institutions, rival fields, unintended consequences, and reality jointly select the outcome. The French Revolution is proposed as an early modern breakthrough in which latent aspirations, sacred principles, recurrent media, feedback, and possible revolutionary overshoot entered one successor-order process; broadcasting appears as hyperdrive, platforms as a reciprocal and self-selecting network, and AI as the possibility of an automated coupling thermostat—or an alignment sovereign. Radermacher supplies an independent precursor: a layered cognitive architecture, humanity as a superorganism, telecommunications as emerging nervous infrastructure, a queen/control bottleneck, and a separate warning that obedient AI could serve a regulated ant state in which individual freedom disappears. The complete AI queen-bee conjunction remains this project's synthesis rather than his claim. A separate high-risk branch proposes that Western Christian marriage rules widened the field beyond the clan, possibly weakened clans as unitary owners of blood debt and corporate liability, and made personal and public liability more useful, while regional European institutions selected for individualist dispositions and possible polygenic distribution change may have altered which mythologies later populations found resonant. Haidt's fast-evolution argument supplies the shared general premise that cultural innovations can alter genetic selection within historical time; the Church–exogamy–European-individualism pathway is the project's stronger extension, not Haidt's conclusion. Northern Italy and the Rhine corridor are proposed selectors and amplifiers within that story, not its sole origin. The strongest recipient-side extension proposes that some real individuality began with partial collar malfunctions: reduced attachment, reception, classification, affect, actuation, jurisdiction, or field transmission, or an open debug port through which the CPU could inspect a still powerful inner judge. Individualist institutions may have turned some such openings into viable CPU-centred rule-following; malfunction alone could instead be destructive, Kant does not establish a genotype, and true homo simplex remains a limiting falsifier rather than an accepted exception to homo duplex. The same receiver branch suggests that an abstract doctrine can remain CPU-centred, undergo first-order recapture, or fail to take hold; the still narrower libertarian-rarity hypothesis predicts an intermediate and uncommon combination rather than a monotonic benefit from malfunction. The same dispositional conflict may help explain why Enlightenment individualists and collectivist successors fought so fiercely for *Deutungshoheit* and for the identity of the real owner. Durkheim's demand to judge doctrines by what they produce adds an offspring audit: recurring descendants are evidence about generative spirit only after entailment, affordance, selection, concealed design, and appropriation are separated. The *Herrschaftsideologie* branch proposes that

exceptional interpreters can turn "X-ray vision" or secular gnosis into jurisdiction, first legitimating rule to themselves and then to the ruled; party-state outcomes are proposed applications, not independent proof of one doctrinal cause. Yet cheaper media can also make rival local orders mutually visible: under plural and protected conditions, the same infrastructure can denaturalize first-order answers and support lifted rules of coexistence. This is a coherent causal research programme, not yet an established history. Its value depends on whether the proposed cost changes, feedback loops, collective states, and historical transitions can be operationalized and survive comparison with rival explanations.

The governing yardstick remains the same as for every analogy in Culture Mechanics: **all models are wrong, but some are useful**. The historical model need not be literally complete to be useful. It must, however, reveal more than it conceals, preserve responsibility and counterexamples, and allow reality to tell us where the story is wrong.